

# Laches

ΛΑΧΗΣ

Plato

*translated by David Horan*

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**LY:** Nicias<sup>1</sup> and Laches, you have seen the man fighting in armour, but we did not tell you at the time why myself and Melesias here invited you to see him with us, but we shall tell you now. Indeed, we believe that it is necessary to speak openly, especially to the two of you. Now, there are some people who are contemptuous of this sort of thing, and if anyone asks them for advice they will not say what they think. Instead they try to guess what advice the person wants, and they say something that is contrary to their own opinion. But we believe that you are men of ample discernment, and based on this discernment you should tell us, in plain terms, what you think about the issues we are about to set before you. Now, the issue that I am leading up to at such length is as follows. We both have these sons: this is my friend's son who bears the name of his grandfather, Thucydides; and this is my son who also bears his grandfather's name, since we call him Aristides, after my father. Now, we have resolved to care for them as best we can, and not to do what most parents do when their sons reach adolescence and allow them to do whatever they wish. No, we have decided to make an immediate start at caring for them as best we can. So, realising that the two of you also have sons, we believed you, if anyone, cared about how they might, with attention, become as excellent as they possibly could. And if it turns out that you have not often thought about this sort of thing, we remind you that it should not be neglected and we invite you to join us in devising some means of caring for our sons. But, Nicias and Laches, you should also hear how we came to these decisions, even if it takes a little longer. In fact, Melesias and I take our meals together and the two lads dine with us. Now, as I also said at the beginning of our conversation, we are going to speak openly to you. For in the case of his own father, each of us can recount numerous noble achievements to the young men, some performed in time of war, some in times of peace, as they managed the affairs of our allies and of this city of ours. But when it comes to our own achievements, neither of us has anything to report. So we are ashamed of this in front of the

boys, and we blame our own fathers for allowing us free rein once we reached adolescence while they were busy with other people's affairs. So we point all this out to the young men, explaining that if they show no care for themselves and pay no heed to us, they will not be famous, while if they do care for themselves they may, perhaps, become worthy of the names they bear. Now, they say that they will heed us, while we for our part are considering what particular subjects or pursuits would render them as excellent as they could possibly be. Now, someone introduced us to this subject of fighting in armour, as a good subject for a young man to learn, and he praised this fellow whose exhibition you have just seen, and then told us to go and see it. So we decided we should go to see the man, and take you two along with us to see him too, and at the same time to be our advisors and, if you wish, co-operate with us in the care of our sons. That's what we wanted to set before you. So at this stage we want you, for your part, to advise us about this particular subject, and whether it should be learned or not, and whether there is any other subject you can recommend for a young man, or any pursuit either. And please tell us how you will respond to the proposed co-operation.

ΛΥ. τεθέασθε μὲν τὸν ἄνδρα μαχόμενον ἐν ὅπλοις, ὃ Νικία τε καὶ Λάχης· οὗ δ' ἔνεκα ὑμᾶς ἐκελεύσαμεν συνθεάσασθαι ἐγὼ τε καὶ Μελησίας ὅδε, τότε μὲν οὐκ εἴπομεν, νῦν δ' ἐροῦμεν. ἡγούμεθα γὰρ χρῆναι πρὸς γε ὑμᾶς παρρησιάζεσθαι. εἰσὶ γάρ τινες οἱ τῶν τοιούτων καταγελῶσι, καὶ ἐάν τις αὐτοῖς συμβουλευέσθαι, οὐκ ἂν εἴποιεν ἄνοοῦσιν, ἀλλὰ στοχαζόμενοι τοῦ συμβουλευομένου ἄλλα λέγουσι παρὰ τὴν αὐτῶν δόξαν· ὑμᾶς δὲ ἡμεῖς ἡγησάμενοι καὶ ἱκανοὺς γινῶναι καὶ γνόντας ἀπλῶς ἂν εἰπεῖν ἃ δοκεῖ ὑμῖν, οὕτω παρελάβομεν ἐπὶ τὴν συμβουλὴν περὶ ὧν μέλλομεν ἀνακοινοῦσθαι. ΛΥ. ἔστιν οὖν τοῦτο, περὶ οὗ πάλαι τοσαῦτα προοιμιάζομαι, τόδε. ἡμῖν εἰσὶν υἱεῖς οὗτοί, ὅδε μὲν τοῦδε, πάππου ἔχων ὄνομα Θουκυδίδης, ἐμὸς δὲ αὖ ὅδε—παππῶν δὲ καὶ οὗτος ὄνομ' ἔχει τοῦμοῦ πατρός· Ἀριστείδην γὰρ αὐτὸν καλοῦμεν—ἡμῖν οὖν τούτων δέδοκται ἐπιμεληθῆναι ὥς οἷόν τε μάλιστα, καὶ μὴ ποιῆσαι ὅπερ οἱ πολλοί, ἐπεὶ δὴ μεῖράκια γέγονεν, ἀνεῖναι αὐτοὺς ὅτι

βούλονται ποιεῖν, ἀλλὰ νῦν δὴ καὶ ἄρχεσθαι αὐτῶν ἐπιμελεῖσθαι καθ' ὅσον οἰοί τ' ἐσμέν. εἰδότες οὖν καὶ ὑμῖν ὑεῖς ὄντας ἡγησάμεθα μεμεληκέναι περὶ αὐτῶν, εἴπερ τισὶν ἄλλοις, πῶς ἂν θεραπευθέντες γένοιτο ἄριστοι εἰ δ' ἄρα πολλάκις μὴ προσεσχέκατε τὸν νοῦν τῷ τοιούτῳ, ὑπομνήσοντες ὅτι οὐ χρὴ αὐτοῦ ἀμελεῖν, καὶ παρακαλοῦντες ὑμᾶς ἐπὶ τὸ ἐπιμέλειάν τινα ποιήσασθαι τῶν ὑέων κοινῇ μεθ' ἡμῶν. ὅθεν δὲ ἡμῖν ταῦτ' ἔδοξεν, ὦ Νικία τε καὶ Λάχης, χρὴ ἀκοῦσαι, κἂν ἢ ὀλίγῳ μακρότερα. συσσιτοῦμεν γὰρ δὴ ἐγώ τε καὶ Μελησίας ὅδε, καὶ ἡμῖν τὰ μειράκια παρασιτεῖ. ὅπερ οὖν καὶ ἀρχόμενος εἶπον τοῦ λόγου, παρρησιασόμεθα πρὸς ὑμᾶς. ἡμῶν γὰρ ἑκάτερος περὶ τοῦ ἑαυτοῦ πατρὸς πολλὰ καὶ καλὰ ἔργα ἔχει λέγειν πρὸς τοὺς νεανίσκους, καὶ ὅσα ἐν πολέμῳ ἡργάσαντο καὶ ὅσα ἐν εἰρήνῃ, διοικοῦντες τὰ τε τῶν συμμάχων καὶ τὰ τῆσδε τῆς πόλεως· ἡμέτερα δ' αὐτῶν ἔργα οὐδέτερος ἔχει λέγειν. ταῦτα δὴ ὑπαισχυνόμεθά τε τούσδε καὶ αἰτιώμεθα τοὺς πατέρας ἡμῶν ὅτι ἡμᾶς μὲν

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**NI:** As for myself, Lysimachus and Melesias, I applaud your idea, and I am ready to cooperate, and I think Laches here will do so too.

εἶων τρυφᾶν, ἐπειδὴ μειράκια ἐγενόμεθα, τὰ δὲ τῶν ἄλλων πράγματα ἔπραττον· καὶ τοῖσδε τοῖς νεανίσκοις αὐτὰ ταῦτα ἐνδεικνύμεθα, λέγοντες ὅτι εἰ μὲν ἀμελήσουσιν ἑαυτῶν καὶ μὴ πείσονται ἡμῖν, ἀκλεεῖς γενήσονται, εἰ δ' ἐπιμελήσονται, τάχ' ἂν τῶν ὀνομάτων ἄξιοι γένοιτο ἃ ἔχουσιν. οὗτοι μὲν οὖν φασιν πείσεσθαι· ἡμεῖς δὲ δὴ τοῦτο σκοποῦμεν, τί ἂν οὗτοι μαθόντες ἢ ἐπιτηδεύσαντες ὅτι ἄριστοι γένοιτο.

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**LA:** Yes, that's true, Nicias. And what Lysimachus said just now about his own father and Melesias' father too is, in my opinion, very relevant to them, to the two of us, and to everyone who engages in civic affairs, because almost as a rule what happens to them is just what he described. Whether it concerns their children or anything else, they set little value upon their private affairs, and manage them without proper care. Now, although you are explaining this very well,

Lysimachus, I am surprised that you are calling upon the two of us as advisors on the education of the young men, and not calling upon Socrates here, who in the first place is from your own district, and secondly, whenever time is being spent on the sort of worthwhile subjects or pursuits for young men that you are seeking, Socrates is there.

εἰσηγήσατο οὖν τις ἡμῖν καὶ τοῦτο τὸ μάθημα, ὅτι καλὸν εἴη τῷ νέῳ μαθεῖν ἐν ὅπλοις μάχεσθαι καὶ ἐπὶ τούτῳ ὃν νῦν ὑμεῖς ἐθεάσασθε ἐπιδεικνύμενον, καὶ ἐκέλευε θεάσασθαι. ἔδοξε δὲ χρῆναι αὐτοὺς τε ἔλθεῖν ἐπὶ θέαν τάνδρως καὶ ὑμᾶς συμπαραλαβεῖν ἅμα μὲν συνθεατάς, ἅμα δὲ συμβούλους τε καὶ κοινωνοὺς, ἐὰν βούλησθε, περὶ τῆς τῶν ὑέων ἐπιμελείας.

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**LY:** What do you mean, Laches? Has Socrates here demonstrated an interest in this sort of thing?

ΛΥ. ταῦτ' ἐστὶν ἃ ἐβουλόμεθα ὑμῖν ἀνακοινώσασθαι. ἤδη οὖν ὑμέτερον μέρος συμβουλευεῖν καὶ περὶ τούτου τοῦ μαθήματος, εἴτε δοκεῖ χρῆναι μανθάνειν εἴτε μή, καὶ περὶ τῶν ἄλλων, εἴ τι ἔχετε ἐπαινέσαι μάθημα νέῳ ἀνδρὶ ἢ ἐπιτήδευμα, καὶ περὶ τῆς κοινωνίας λέγειν ὁποῖόν τι ποιήσετε. ΝΙ. ἐγὼ μὲν, ὦ Λυσίμαχε καὶ Μελησίᾳ, ἐπαινῶ τε ὑμῶν τὴν διάνοιαν καὶ κοινωνεῖν ἔτοιμος, οἷμαι δὲ καὶ Λάχητα τόνδε.

**LA:** Yes, certainly, Lysimachus.

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**NI:** I can tell you about this too, just as well as Laches can. In fact, Socrates recently recommended a music teacher to me for my own son. His name is Damon<sup>2</sup>, a pupil of Agathocles, and the most accomplished of men, not only in music, but in anything else you might deem worthwhile for young men to engage in at that age.

ΛΑ. ἀληθῆ γὰρ οἶει, ὦ Νικία. ὥς ὃ γε ἔλεγεν ὁ Λυσίμαχος ἄρτι περὶ τοῦ πατρὸς τοῦ αὐτοῦ τε καὶ τοῦ Μελησίου, πάνυ μοι δοκεῖ εὖ εἰρησθαι καὶ εἰς ἐκείνους καὶ εἰς ἡμᾶς καὶ εἰς ἅπαντας ὅσοι τὰ τῶν πόλεων πράττουσιν, ὅτι αὐτοῖς σχεδόν τι ταῦτα συμβαίνει ἃ οὗτος λέγει καὶ

περὶ παῖδας καὶ περὶ τᾶλλα, τὰ ἴδια ὀλιγωρεῖσθαι τε καὶ ἀμελῶς διατίθεσθαι. ταῦτα μὲν οὖν καλῶς λέγεις, ὦ Λυσίμαχε· ὅτι δ' ἡμᾶς μὲν συμβούλους παρακαλεῖς ἐπὶ τὴν τῶν νεανίσκων

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**LY:** Well, Socrates, Nicias, and Laches, men of my age do not really understand young people any more, since we spend most of our time at home because of our age. But if you, son of Sophroniscus, have any good advice to give to someone from your own district, then you should advise me. It is only right that you should. In fact, it so happens that you are my friend, through your father, since myself and your father were friends and associates, and to the day he died he never fell out with me. But something is coming back to me, and I am reminded from what has just been said, that when the young lads here are conversing with one another at home, they often mention Socrates, and they praise him highly. Yet I never asked them if they are referring to the son of Sophroniscus. So, boys, tell me, is this the Socrates you mention so often?

παιδείαν, Σωκράτη δὲ τόνδε οὐ παρακαλεῖς, θαυμάζω, πρῶτον μὲν ὄντα δημότην, ἔπειτα ἐνταῦθα ἀεὶ τὰς διατριβὰς ποιούμενον ὅπου τί ἐστὶ τῶν τοιούτων ὧν σὺ ζητεῖς περὶ τοὺς νέους ἢ μάθημα ἢ ἐπιτήδευμα καλόν. ΛΥ. πῶς λέγεις, ὦ Λάχης; Σωκράτης γὰρ ὅδε τινὸς τῶν τοιούτων ἐπιμέλειαν πεποιήται; ΛΑ. πάνυ μὲν οὖν, ὦ Λυσίμαχε. ΝΙ. τοῦτο μὲν σοι κἂν ἐγὼ ἔχοιμι εἰπεῖν οὐ χεῖρον Λάχητος· καὶ γὰρ αὐτῷ μοι ἔναγχος ἄνδρα προὔξηνεσε τῷ

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**BO:** Certainly, father. This is the man.

ὕεῖ διδάσκαλον μουσικῆς, Ἀγαθοκλέους μαθητὴν Δάμωνα, ἀνδρῶν χαριέστατον οὐ μόνον τὴν μουσικὴν, ἀλλὰ καὶ τᾶλλα ὁπόσου βούλει ἄξιον συνδιατρίβειν τηλικούτοις νεανίσκοις. ΛΥ. οὗτοι, ὦ Σώκρατες τε καὶ Νικία καὶ Λάχης, οἱ ἡλίκοι ἐγὼ ἔτι γινώσκομεν τοὺς νεωτέρους, ἅτε κατ' οἰκίαν τὰ πολλὰ διατρίβοντες ὑπὸ τῆς ἡλικίας· ἀλλ' εἴ τι καὶ σύ, ὦ παῖ Σωφρονίσκου, ἔχεις τῷδε τῷ σαυτοῦ δημότῃ ἀγαθόν

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**LY:** Well, by Hera, Socrates, it is good to see that you do right by your father, the best of men, especially in view of the mutual family connections that are about to be established between ourselves.

συμβουλευσαι, χρή συμβουλεύειν. δίκαιος δ' εἶ· καὶ γὰρ πατρικὸς ἡμῖν φίλος τυγχάνεις ὧν· αἰεὶ γὰρ ἐγὼ καὶ ὁ σὸς πατὴρ ἐταίρω τε καὶ φίλῳ ἤμεν, καὶ πρότερον ἐκεῖνος ἐτελεύτησε, πρὶν τι ἐμοὶ διενεχθῆναι. ΛΥ. περιφέρει δέ τις με καὶ μνήμη ἄρτι τῶνδε λεγόντων· τὰ γὰρ μειράκια τὰδε πρὸς ἀλλήλους οἴκοι διαλεγόμενοι θαμὰ ἐπιμέμνηνται Σωκράτους καὶ σφόδρα ἐπαινοῦσιν· οὐ μέντοι πώποτε αὐτοὺς ἀνηρώτησα

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**LA:** Yes, indeed, Lysimachus, you should not let this man go. For I have also seen him elsewhere, doing right not only by his father but by his fatherland too. Yes, he retreated alongside me in the flight from Delium<sup>3</sup>, and I am telling you that if the others had been prepared to act as he acted, our city would be standing tall, and a calamity like that would never have befallen her.

εἰ τὸν Σωφρονίσκου λέγοιεν. ἀλλ', ὦ παῖδες, λέγετέ μοι, ὅδ' ἐστὶ Σωκράτης, περὶ οὗ ἐκάστοτε ἐμέμνησθε; ΠΑΙ. πάννυ μὲν οὖν, ὦ πάτερ, οὗτος. ΛΥ. εὖ γε νῆ τὴν Ἥραν, ὦ Σώκρατες, ὅτι ὀρθοῖς τὸν πατέρα, ἄριστον ἀνδρῶν ὄντα, καὶ ἄλλως καὶ δὴ καὶ ὅτι οἰκεῖα τά τε σὰ ἡμῖν ὑπάρξει καὶ σοὶ τὰ ἡμέτερα. ΛΑ. καὶ μὲν, ὦ Λυσίμαχε, μὴ ἀφίεσό γε τάνδρος· ὡς ἐγὼ καὶ ἄλλοθί γε αὐτὸν ἐθεασάμην οὐ μόνον τὸν πατέρα

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**LY:** This is fine praise indeed, Socrates, since it comes from trustworthy men, and because of the qualities they are praising in you. Now, rest assured that when I hear all this I am delighted that you are held in high esteem, and you should count me among those who have the highest regard for you. Now, you yourself really should have paid us a visit long before this and treated us as family. It is only right that you should. But from now on, since we now recognise one another, you have no choice but to get to know us, and make the acquaintance of ourselves and these young fellows here, so that you may preserve our

mutual friendship. Well, you will do this of course, and we shall remind you again. However, what do you have to say about our initial discussion topic? What do you think? Is the subject suitable for the young men or not, I mean learning how to fight in armour?

ἀλλὰ καὶ τὴν πατρίδα ὀρθοῦντα· ἐν γὰρ τῇ ἀπὸ Δηλίου φυγῇ μετ' ἐμοῦ συνανεχώρει, καὶ γὰρ σοι λέγω ὅτι εἰ οἱ ἄλλοι ἤθελον τοιοῦτοι εἶναι, ὀρθὴ ἂν ἡμῶν ἡ πόλις ἦν καὶ οὐκ ἂν ἔπρεσε τότε τοιοῦτον πτόμα. ΛΥ. ὦ Σώκρατες, οὗτος μέντοι ὁ ἔπαινός ἐστιν καλός, ὃν σὺ νῦν ἐπαινῇ ὑπ' ἀνδρῶν ἀξίων πιστεύεσθαι καὶ εἰς ταῦτα εἰς ἃ οὗτοι ἐπαινοῦσιν. εὖ οὖν ἴσθι ὅτι ἐγὼ ταῦτα ἀκούων χαίρω ὅτι εὐδοκιμεῖς, καὶ σὺ δὲ ἡγοῦ με ἐν τοῖς εὐνοούστατόν σοι εἶναι. χρῆν μὲν οὖν καὶ πρότερόν γε φοιτᾶν αὐτὸν παρ' ἡμᾶς καὶ οἰκείους ἡγεῖσθαι, ὥσπερ τὸ δίκαιον· νῦν δ' οὖν ἀπὸ τῆσδε τῆς ἡμέρας, ἐπειδὴ ἀνεγνωρίσαμεν ἀλλήλους, μὴ ἄλλως ποίει, ἀλλὰ σύνισθί τε καὶ γνῶριζε καὶ ἡμᾶς καὶ τούσδε τοὺς νεωτέρους, ὅπως ἂν διασώζητε καὶ ὑμεῖς τὴν ἡμετέραν φιλίαν. ταῦτα μὲν οὖν καὶ σὺ ποιήσεις καὶ ἡμεῖς σε καὶ αὐθις ὑπομνήσομεν· περὶ δὲ ὧν ἡρξάμεθα τί φατε; τί δοκεῖ; τὸ μάθημα τοῖς μεираκίοις ἐπιτήδειον εἶναι ἢ οὐ, τὸ μαθεῖν ἐν ὅπλοις μάχεσθαι;

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**S:** Well, Lysimachus, I shall try to advise you about this matter as best I can, and what is more, I shall also do everything else you are asking me to do. However, since I am younger than anyone else here, and less experienced than they are, I think that what is most fitting is that I first listen to what they say and learn from them. Then, if I have anything to add to what they say, I should provide instruction at that stage, and try to convince yourself and these men too. Well, Nicias, why does one of you not speak first?

ΣΩ. ἀλλὰ καὶ τούτων πέρι, ὦ Λυσίμαχε, ἔγωγε πειράσομαι συμβουλεύειν ἅν τι δύνωμαι, καὶ αὖ ἃ προκαλῇ πάντα ποιεῖν. δικαιοτάτον μέντοι μοι δοκεῖ εἶναι ἐμὲ νεώτερον ὄντα τῶνδε καὶ ἀπειρότερον τούτων ἀκούειν πρότερον τί λέγουσιν καὶ μανθάνειν παρ' αὐτῶν· ἐὰν δ' ἔχω τι ἄλλο παρὰ τὰ ὑπὸ τούτων λεγόμενα, τότε ἤδη

διδάσκειν καὶ πείθειν καὶ σὲ καὶ τούτους. ἀλλ', ὦ Νικία, τί οὐ λέγει πότερος ὑμῶν; ΝΙ. ἀλλ' οὐδὲν κωλύει, ὦ Σώκρατες. δοκεῖ γὰρ καὶ

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**NI:** There is no reason not to, Socrates. Indeed, it seems to me that knowledge of this subject is of benefit to the young in lots of ways. In fact, it would be well for the young people to spend their time in this, rather than the pursuits they normally like to engage in when they are at leisure. This must improve their bodies, for it is just as good and just as strenuous as any physical exercise, and, at the same time, this exercise, and horsemanship too, are most appropriate to a free man. For only those who exercise with these instruments of war are trained in the struggle in which we engage and in the instruments upon which our struggle depends. What's more, this subject will also be of some benefit in the battle itself, when it is necessary to fight in ranks alongside many others. However, its greatest benefit is when the ranks are broken and you must then fight one on one, either when pursuing someone who is warding off your attack, or when you yourself are in retreat and must ward off an attack by someone else. Someone with knowledge of this subject would suffer no harm when faced with a single opponent, or perhaps when faced with many. He would have the advantage in any situation. Then again, something like this also awakens an interest in another noble subject, for everyone who learns how to fight in armour would also develop an interest in the related subject of military tactics, and once he had grasped these and taken pride in them, he might then tackle the subject of generalship. And it is obvious by now that anything related to these, and all the subjects and pursuits that are noble and well worthwhile for a man to learn and practise, would all have their origin in this subject. But we should make an additional point, and it is not an insignificant one. This knowledge would make any man much bolder and braver in battle than he was before. And we should not disdain to mention, even if some think it is insignificant, that he will look more impressive where a man needs to look more impressive, where he needs to appear more

formidable to the enemy because of his impressive appearance. So, Lysimachus, it seems to me, as I say, that these subjects should be taught to young men, and I have told you why I think so. But if Laches has a contrary view, I would gladly listen to it.

ἐμοὶ τοῦτο τὸ μάθημα τοῖς νέοις ὠφέλιμον εἶναι ἐπίστασθαι πολλαχῇ. ΝΙ. καὶ γὰρ τὸ μὴ ἄλλοθι διατρίβειν, ἐν οἷς δὴ φιλοῦσιν οἱ νέοι τὰς διατριβὰς ποιεῖσθαι ὅταν σχολὴν ἄγωσιν, ἀλλ' ἐν τούτῳ, εὖ ἔχει, ὅθεν καὶ τὸ σῶμα βέλτιον ἴσχειν ἀνάγκη—οὐδενὸς γὰρ τῶν γυμνασίων φαυλότερον οὐδ' ἐλάττω πόνον ἔχει—καὶ ἅμα προσήκει μάλιστα ἔλευθέρῳ τοῦτό τε τὸ γυμνάσιον καὶ ἡ ἵππικὴ· οὗ γὰρ ἀγῶνος ἀθληταὶ ἐσμεν καὶ ἐν οἷς ἡμῖν ὁ ἀγὼν πρόκειται, μόνοι οὗτοι γυμνάζονται οἱ ἐν τούτοις τοῖς τὸν περὶ τὸν πόλεμον ὀργάνοις γυμναζόμενοι. ἔπειτα ὀνήσει μὲν τι τοῦτο τὸ μάθημα καὶ ἐν τῇ μάχῃ αὐτῇ, ὅταν ἐν τάξει δέῃ μάχεσθαι μετὰ πολλῶν ἄλλων· μέγιστον μέντοι αὐτοῦ ὄφελος, ὅταν λυθῶσιν αἱ τάξεις καὶ ἤδη τι δέῃ μόνον πρὸς μόνον ἢ διώκοντα ἀμυνομένῳ τινὶ ἐπιθέσθαι ἢ καὶ ἐν φυγῇ ἐπιτιθεμένου ἄλλου ἀμύνεσθαι αὐτόν· οὗτ' ἂν ὑπὸ γε ἐνὸς εἰς ὁ τοῦτ' ἐπιστάμενος οὐδὲν ἂν πάθοι, ἴσως δ' οὐδὲ ὑπὸ πλειόνων, ἀλλὰ πανταχῇ ἂν ταύτῃ πλεονεκτοῖ. ἔτι δὲ καὶ εἰς ἄλλου καλοῦ μαθήματος ἐπιθυμίαν παρακαλεῖ τὸ τοιοῦτον· πᾶς γὰρ ἂν μαθὼν ἐν ὅπλοις μάχεσθαι ἐπιθυμήσειε καὶ τοῦ ἐξῆς μαθήματος τοῦ περὶ τὰς τάξεις, καὶ ταῦτα λαβὼν καὶ φιλοτιμηθεὶς ἐν αὐτοῖς ἐπὶ πᾶν ἂν τὸ περὶ τὰς στρατηγίας ὀρμήσειε· καὶ ἤδη δῆλον ὅτι τὰ τούτων ἐχόμενα καὶ μαθήματα πάντα καὶ ἐπιτηδεύματα καὶ καλὰ καὶ πολλοῦ ἄξια ἀνδρὶ μαθεῖν τε καὶ ἐπιτηδεῦσαι, ὧν καθηγήσαιτ' ἂν τοῦτο τὸ μάθημα. προσθήσομεν δ' αὐτῷ οὐ σμικρὰν προσθήκην, ὅτι πάντα ἄνδρα ἐν πολέμῳ καὶ θαρραλεώτερον καὶ ἀνδρείοτερον ἂν ποιήσειεν αὐτὸν αὐτοῦ οὐκ ὀλίγῳ αὕτη ἡ ἐπιστήμη. μὴ ἀτιμάσωμεν δὲ εἰπεῖν, εἰ καὶ τῷ σμικρότερον δοκεῖ εἶναι, ὅτι καὶ εὐσχημονέστερον ἐνταῦθα οὐ χρὴ τὸν ἄνδρα εὐσχημονέστερον

182d

**LA:** Well, Nicias, to take any subject at all and say that it should not be learned presents a difficulty, since it does seem good to know everything. And if this armour business is indeed a subject, as its

instructors claim and as Nicias says, then it should be learned. But if it is not a subject, and those who promise to teach it are deceiving us, or if it is actually a subject but not a very serious one, what need could there be to learn it? And I am saying this about it based upon the following observation: I think that if it amounted to anything it would not have been overlooked by the Spartans, people whose sole concern in life is to seek out and practise any subject or pursuit that might give them an advantage over others in war. And if these people have overlooked it, then the teachers of this subject surely have not overlooked the fact that, among the Greeks, the Spartans are the ones who are most serious about such matters, and that anyone who has won respect among them in this area would also make a great deal of money from the other cities, just as a tragedian does when he has won respect among ourselves. As a result, anyone who thinks that he is a good tragedian does not make a circuit of Attica, putting on performances in all the other outlying cities. No, he makes his way here directly and puts on a performance for us. It is the reasonable thing to do. But I observe that those who fight in armour regard Sparta as sacred ground, and they do not set even a toe there. They make their way around the city in a circle and would prefer to put on a performance for anyone else at all, especially for those who would confess that when it comes to warfare, lots of other cities are superior to themselves. And, Lysimachus, I have come across quite a few of these people in action and I have seen what they are like. So we may also consider the matter on this basis. Indeed, as a rule, not a single person who has practised fighting in armour has ever won fame in battle. Even though, in all the other disciplines, the people who become famous are the ones who practise, these fellows, in contrast it seems, meet with stark misfortune. Yes, and this Stesilaus, whom you saw along with me, putting on that performance in front of such a large crowd and making those great claims that he made about himself, well, I saw him elsewhere, in a real battle, actually putting on a better performance unintentionally. The ship he was serving on had rammed

a transport vessel and he was fighting with an unusual weapon, a ‘spear-pike’ – as unusual as the man himself. Now, his general exploits are hardly worth recounting, except for the details of what happened to the spear-pike. For as he was fighting, it somehow got caught in the rigging of the other ship and wouldn’t budge. So Stesilaus tugged at it in an effort to free it but he was not able to, and the ships were moving. Well, at first he ran along the deck, holding onto the weapon, but then the other ship began to draw away and it dragged him after it, still holding on. He allowed the weapon to slip through his hands until he was left holding onto the end of the shaft. There was laughter and derisory applause from the men on the transporter at the sight of the fellow, and when someone threw a stone that landed on the deck at his feet, he finally let go of the spear-pike. By then, even the men on his own ship were no longer able to contain their laughter when they saw his weapon flapping about on the transporter. Now, all this may perhaps amount to something, as Nicias says, but those whom I have met are people like Stesilaus. So, as I said initially, whether it is a subject but of little benefit, or it is not a subject but people claim that it is and pretend that it is, in either case it is not worth trying to learn it. In fact, it seems to me that if a coward were to believe that he knew this subject, he would become bolder because of it, and the sort of man he actually is would become more obvious, while if a brave man were to do so, he would be under scrutiny from everyone else and would attract enormous criticism at even the slightest mistake. For pretensions to this sort of wisdom produce envy, and unless a man excels over others in excellence to an amazing extent, there is no way he can avoid becoming a laughing stock by claiming to possess this knowledge. Such is my opinion, Lysimachus, of any effort expended upon this subject. But as I told you initially, you should not let Socrates here go, but you should ask for his advice, based on his view of the issue before us.

φαίνεσθαι, οὗ ἅμα καὶ δεινότερος τοῖς ἐχθροῖς φανεῖται διὰ τὴν εὐσχημοσύνην. ἐμοὶ μὲν οὖν, ὦ Λυσίμαχε, ὥσπερ λέγω, δοκεῖ τε χρῆναι

διδάσκειν τοὺς νεανίσκους ταῦτα καὶ δι' ἃ δοκεῖ εἶρηκα· Λάχητος δ', εἴ  
 τι παρὰ ταῦτα λέγει, κἂν αὐτὸς ἡδέως ἀκούσαιοι. ΛΑ. ἀλλ' ἔστι μὲν, ὧ  
 Νικία, χαλεπὸν λέγειν περὶ οὗτου οὖν μαθήματος ὥς οὐ χρή μανθάνειν·  
 πάντα γὰρ ἐπίστασθαι ἀγαθὸν δοκεῖ εἶναι. καὶ δὴ καὶ τὸ ὀπλιτικὸν  
 τοῦτο, εἰ μὲν ἐστὶν μάθημα, ὅπερ φασὶν οἱ διδάσκοντες, καὶ οἷον Νικίας  
 λέγει, χρή αὐτὸ μανθάνειν· εἰ δ' ἔστιν μὲν μὴ μάθημα, ἀλλ' ἐξαπατῶσιν  
 οἱ ὑπισχνούμενοι, ἢ μάθημα μὲν τυγχάνει ὄν, μὴ μέντοι πάνυ  
 σπουδαῖον, τί καὶ δέοι ἂν αὐτὸ μανθάνειν; ΛΑ. λέγω δὲ ταῦτα περὶ  
 αὐτοῦ εἰς τὰδε ἀποβλέψας, ὅτι οἶμαι ἐγὼ τοῦτο, εἰ τί ἦν, οὐκ ἂν  
 λεληθέναι Λακεδαιμονίους, οἷς οὐδὲν ἄλλο μέλει ἐν τῷ βίῳ ἢ τοῦτο  
 ζητεῖν καὶ ἐπιτηδεύειν, ὅτι ἂν μαθόντες καὶ ἐπιτηδεύσαντες  
 πλεονεκτοῖεν τῶν ἄλλων περὶ τὸν πόλεμον. εἰ δ' ἐκείνους λέληθεν,  
 ἀλλ' οὐ τούτους γε τοὺς διδασκάλους αὐτοῦ λέληθεν αὐτὸ τοῦτο, ὅτι  
 ἐκείνοι μάλιστα τῶν Ἑλλήνων σπουδάζουσιν ἐπὶ τοῖς τοιούτοις καὶ ὅτι  
 παρ' ἐκείνοις ἂν τις τιμηθεῖς εἰς ταῦτα καὶ παρὰ τῶν ἄλλων πλεῖστ' ἂν  
 ἐργάζοιτο χρήματα, ὥσπερ γε καὶ τραγωδίας ποιητῆς παρ' ἡμῖν  
 τιμηθεῖς. τοιγάρτοι ὃς ἂν οἴηται τραγωδίαν καλῶς ποιεῖν, οὐκ ἔξωθεν  
 κύκλῳ περὶ τὴν Ἀττικὴν κατὰ τὰς ἄλλας πόλεις ἐπιδεικνύμενος  
 περιέρχεται, ἀλλ' εὐθὺς δεῦρο φέρεται καὶ τοῖσδ' ἐπιδείκνυσιν εἰκότως·  
 τοὺς δὲ ἐν ὅπλοις μαχομένους ἐγὼ τούτους ὁρῶ τὴν μὲν Λακεδαίμονα  
 ἡγουμένους εἶναι ἄβατον ἱερὸν καὶ οὐδὲ ἄκρῳ ποδὶ ἐπιβαίνοντας,  
 κύκλῳ δὲ περιιόντας αὐτὴν καὶ πᾶσι μᾶλλον ἐπιδεικνυμένους, καὶ  
 μάλιστα τούτοις οἱ κἂν αὐτοὶ ὁμολογήσειαν πολλοὺς σφῶν προτέρους  
 εἶναι πρὸς τὰ τοῦ πολέμου. ἔπειτα, ὧ Λυσίμαχε, οὐ πάνυ ὀλίγοις ἐγὼ  
 τούτων παραγέγονα ἐν αὐτῷ τῷ ἔργῳ, καὶ ὁρῶ οἱοί εἰσιν. ἔξεστι δὲ καὶ  
 αὐτόθεν ἡμῖν σκέψασθαι. ὥσπερ γὰρ ἐπίτηδες οὐδεὶς πώποτ' εὐδόκιμος  
 γέγονεν ἐν τῷ πολέμῳ ἀνὴρ τῶν τὰ ὀπλιτικὰ ἐπιτηδευσάντων. καίτοι  
 εἷς γε τᾶλλα πάντα ἐκ τούτων οἱ ὀνομαστοὶ γίνονται, ἐκ τῶν  
 ἐπιτηδευσάντων ἕκαστα· οὗτοι δ', ὥς ἔοικε, παρὰ τοὺς ἄλλους οὕτω  
 σφόδρα εἰς τοῦτο δεδυστυχήκασιν. ἐπεὶ καὶ τοῦτον τὸν Στησίλεων, ὃν  
 ὑμεῖς μετ' ἐμοῦ ἐν τοσοῦτῳ ὄχλῳ ἐθεάσασθε ἐπιδεικνύμενον καὶ τὰ  
 μεγάλα περὶ αὐτοῦ λέγοντα ἃ ἔλεγεν, ἐτέρωθι ἐγὼ κάλλιον ἐθεασάμην  
 ἐν τῇ ἀληθείᾳ ὥς ἀληθῶς ἐπιδεικνύμενον οὐχ ἐκόντα. προσβαλοῦσης

γὰρ τῆς νεῶς ἐφ' ἧ ἐπεβάτευεν πρὸς ὀλκάδα τινά, ἐμάχετο ἔχων δορυδρέπανον, διαφέρον δὴ ὄπλον ἅτε καὶ αὐτὸς τῶν ἄλλων διαφέρων. τὰ μὲν οὖν ἄλλα οὐκ ἄξια λέγειν περὶ τάνδρός, τὸ δὲ σόφισμα τὸ τοῦ δρεπάνου τοῦ πρὸς τῇ λόγχῃ οἷον ἀπέβη. μαχομένου γὰρ αὐτοῦ ἐνέσχετό που ἐν τοῖς τῆς νεῶς σκεύεσιν καὶ ἀντελάβετο· εἶλκεν οὖν ὁ Στησίλεως βουλόμενος ἀπολῦσαι, καὶ οὐχ οἷός τ' ἦν, ἡ δὲ ναὺς τὴν ναῦν παρήει. ΛΑ. τέως μὲν οὖν παρέθει ἐν τῇ νηὶ ἀντεχόμενος τοῦ δόρατος· ἐπεὶ δὲ δὴ παρημείβετο ἡ ναὺς τὴν ναῦν καὶ ἐπέσπα αὐτὸν τοῦ δόρατος ἐχόμενον, ἐφίει τὸ δόρυ διὰ τῆς χειρός, ἕως ἄκρου τοῦ στύρακος ἀντελάβετο. ἦν δὲ γέλως καὶ κρότος ὑπὸ τῶν ἐκ τῆς ὀλκάδος ἐπὶ τε τῷ σχήματι αὐτοῦ, καὶ ἐπειδὴ βαλόντος τινὸς λίθω παρὰ τοὺς πόδας αὐτοῦ ἐπὶ τὸ κατὰστροφμα ἀφίεται τοῦ δόρατος, τότε ἤδη καὶ οἱ ἐκ τῆς τριήρους οὐκέτι οἰοί τ' ἦσαν τὸν γέλωτα κατέχειν, ὀρῶντες αἰωρούμενον ἐκ τῆς ὀλκάδος τὸ δορυδρέπανον ἐκεῖνο. ἴσως μὲν οὖν εἴη ἂν τὰ ταῦτα, ὥσπερ Νικίας λέγει· οἷς δ' οὖν ἐγὼ ἐντετύχηκα, τοιαῦτ' ἅττα ἐστίν. ὁ οὖν καὶ ἐξ ἀρχῆς εἶπον, εἴτε οὕτω σμικρὰς ὠφελίας ἔχει μάθημα ὄν, εἴτε μὴ ὄν φασὶ καὶ προσποιοῦνται αὐτὸ εἶναι μάθημα, οὐκ ἄξιον ἐπιχειρεῖν μανθάνειν. καὶ γὰρ οὖν μοι δοκεῖ, εἰ μὲν δειλὸς τις ὢν οἰοίτο αὐτὸ ἐπίστασθαι, θρασύτερος ἂν δι' αὐτὸ γενόμενος ἐπιφανέστερος γένοιτο οἷος ἦν, εἰ δὲ ἀνδρεῖος, φυλαττόμενος ἂν ὑπὸ τῶν ἀνθρώπων, εἰ καὶ σμικρὸν ἐξαμάρτοι, μεγάλας ἂν διαβολὰς ἴσχειν·

184c

**LY:** Well, I am asking you, Socrates. In fact, our meeting seems to me to require a sort of casting vote. For if these two men had concurred, there would be less need for this, but now, as you see, Laches has voted the opposite way to Nicias, so it would be nice to hear from you too. Which of the two men do you vote with?

ἐπίφθονος γὰρ ἡ προσποιήσις τῆς τοιαύτης ἐπιστήμης, ὥστ' εἰ μή τι θαυμαστὸν ὅσον διαφέρει τῇ ἀρετῇ τῶν ἄλλων, οὐκ ἔσθ' ὅπως ἂν τις φύγοι τὸ καταγέλαστο γενέσθαι φάσκων ἔχειν ταύτην τὴν ἐπιστήμην. τοιαύτη τις ἔμοιγε δοκεῖ, ὦ Λυσίμαχε, ἡ περὶ τοῦτο τὸ μάθημα εἶναι σπουδὴ χρὴ δ' ὅπερ σοι ἐξ ἀρχῆς ἔλεγον, καὶ Σωκράτη τόνδε μὴ

ἀφιέναι, ἀλλὰ δεῖσθαι συμβουλεύειν ὅπῃ δοκεῖ αὐτῷ περὶ τοῦ προκειμένου. ΛΥ. ἀλλὰ δέομαι ἔγωγε, ὦ Σώκρατες· καὶ γὰρ ὥσπερ

184d

**S:** What's this, Lysimachus? Are you going to adopt the stance that the majority of us approve of?

τοῦ ἐπιδιακρινούντος δοκεῖ μοι δεῖν ἡμῖν ἡ βουλή. εἰ μὲν γὰρ συνεφερέσθην τῷδε, ἦττον ἂν τοῦ τοιούτου ἔδει· νῦν δὲ τὴν ἐναντίαν γάρ, ὡς ὀρᾷς, Λάχης Νικίᾳ ἔθετο, εὖ δὴ ἔχει ἀκοῦσαι καὶ σοῦ ποτέρῳ τοῖν ἀνδροῖν σύμψηφος εἶ. ΣΩ. τί δέ, ὦ Λυσίμαχε; ὁπότερ' ἂν οἱ πλείους ἐπαινῶσιν ἡμῶν, τούτοις μέλλεις χρῆσθαι; ΛΥ. τί γὰρ ἂν τις καὶ ποιοῖ, ὦ Σώκρατες; ΣΩ. ἦ καὶ σύ, ὦ Μελησία, οὕτως ἂν ποιοῖς; κἂν εἴ

**LY:** What else could anyone do, Socrates?

184e

**S:** And you, Melesias, would you do the same? Even if you had a meeting about how your son should exercise for a competition, would you be persuaded by the majority of us or by that person who happens to have been educated and exercised under a good trainer?

τις περὶ ἀγωνίας τοῦ ὑέος σοι βουλή εἴη τί χρὴ ἀσκεῖν, ἄρα τοῖς πλείοσιν ἂν ἡμῶν πείθοιο, ἢ 'κείνῳ ὅστις τυγχάνει ὑπὸ παιδοτρίβῃ ἀγαθῷ πεπαιδευμένος καὶ ἡσκηκώς; ΜΕ. ἐκείνῳ εἰκός γε, ὦ Σώκρατες. ΣΩ. αὐτῷ ἄρ' ἂν μᾶλλον πείθοιο ἢ τέτταρσιν οὗσιν ἡμῖν; ΜΕ. ἴσως. ΣΩ. ἐπιστήμη γὰρ οἶμαι δεῖ κρίνεσθαι ἀλλ' οὐ πλήθει τὸ μέλλον καλῶς κριθήσεσθαι. ΜΕ. πῶς γὰρ οὐ; ΣΩ. οὐκοῦν καὶ νῦν χρὴ πρῶτον αὐτὸ τοῦτο σκέψασθαι,

**MEL:** By that person, Socrates, more likely.

**S:** So, would you be more persuaded by him than by the four of us?

**MEL:** Probably.

**S:** Because, I presume, an issue should be decided based upon knowledge rather than numbers, if it is to be decided aright.

**MEL:** Of course.

185a

**S:** So, in this case too, we should first consider this particular question. Is there or is there not anyone among us who is skilled in the matter we are deliberating upon? And if there is, we should be persuaded by that one person and bid the others farewell. But if there is not, we should search for someone else to advise us. Or do you and Lysimachus think that what is now at stake is insignificant and does not concern what is actually the most important of your possessions? For, I believe, the entire estate of the father will be managed based upon the sort of people the children become, and whether or not the sons turn out well.

εἰ ἔστιν τις ἡμῶν τεχνικὸς περὶ οὗ βουλευόμεθα ἢ οὐ καὶ εἰ μὲν ἔστιν, ἐκεῖνῳ πείθεσθαι ἐνὶ ὄντι, τοὺς δ' ἄλλους ἔαν, εἰ δὲ μή, ἄλλον τινὰ ζητεῖν. ἢ περὶ σμικροῦ οἴεσθε νυνὶ κινδυνεύειν καὶ σὺ καὶ Λυσίμαχος ἀλλ' οὐ περὶ τούτου τοῦ κτήματος ὃ τῶν ὑμετέρων μέγιστον ὄν τυγχάνει; ὑέων γάρ που ἢ χρηστῶν ἢ τάναντία γενομένων καὶ πᾶς ὁ οἶκος ὃ τοῦ πατρὸς οὕτως οἰκήσεται, ὅποιοι ἂν τινες οἱ παῖδες γένωνται. ME. ἀληθῆ λέγεις. ΣΩ. πολλὴν ἄρα δεῖ προμηθίαν αὐτοῦ ἔχειν. ME. πάνυ γε.

**MEL:** That's true.

**S:** So it must be given a great deal of forethought.

**MEL:** Certainly.

185b

**S:** Now, on the issue I just mentioned, how would we proceed if we wished to consider which of us is most skilled in the area of competitive contests? Would he not be the person who has learned and practised, and who has had good teachers of this particular skill?

ΣΩ. πῶς οὖν, ὃ ἐγὼ ἄρτι ἔλεγον, ἐσκοποῦμεν ἄν, εἰ ἐβουλόμεθα σκέψασθαι τίς ἡμῶν περὶ ἀγωνίαν τεχνικώτατος; ἄρ' οὐχ ὁ μαθὼν καὶ ἐπιτηδεύσας, ᾧ καὶ διδάσκαλοι ἀγαθοὶ γεγονότες ἦσαν αὐτοῦ τούτου; ME. ἔμοιγε δοκεῖ. ΣΩ. οὐκοῦν ἔτι πρότερον, τίνοος ὄντος τούτου οὗ ζητοῦμεν τοὺς διδασκάλους; ME. πῶς λέγεις; ΣΩ. ὥδε ἴσως μᾶλλον

κατάδηλον ἔσται. οὐ μοι δοκεῖ ἐξ ἀρχῆς ἡμῖν ὠμολογηθῆναι τί ποτ' ἔστιν περὶ οὗ βουλευόμεθα καὶ σκεπτόμεθα, ὅστις ἡμῶν τεχνικὸς καὶ τούτου

**MEL:** I think so.

**S:** Even before that, should we not consider what this subject, whose teachers we are seeking, actually is?

**MEL:** What do you mean?

**S:** Perhaps this will be more obvious as follows. I do not think we agreed at the outset what exactly it is that we are deliberating about and considering when we ask who among us is skilled in this, and who has acquired teachers for the sake of this, and who has not.

185c

**NI:** But, Socrates, aren't we discussing armour fighting and whether the young men should learn this or not?

ἔνεκα διδασκάλους ἐκτήσατο, καὶ ὅστις μή. NI. οὐ γάρ, ὦ Σώκρατες, περὶ τοῦ ἐν ὅλοις μάχεσθαι σκοποῦμεν, εἴτε χρὴ αὐτὸ τοὺς νεανίσκους μανθάνειν εἴτε μή; ΣΩ. πάνυ μὲν οὖν, ὦ Νικία. ἀλλ' ὅταν περὶ φαρμάκου τίς του πρὸς ὀφθαλμοὺς σκοπῇται, εἴτε χρὴ αὐτὸ ὑπαλείφεσθαι εἴτε μή, πότερον οἶει τότε εἶναι τὴν βουλήν περὶ τοῦ φαρμάκου ἢ περὶ τῶν ὀφθαλμῶν; NI. περὶ τῶν ὀφθαλμῶν.

185d

**S:** Yes, certainly, Nicias, but when someone is considering a medicine for his eyes, and whether it should be applied or not, do you think his deliberation at that time is about the medicine or his eyes?

ΣΩ. οὐκοῦν καὶ ὅταν ἵπῳ χαλινὸν σκοπῇται τις εἰ προσοιστέον ἢ μή, καὶ ὅποτε, τότε που περὶ τοῦ ἵππου βουλεύεται ἀλλ' οὐ περὶ τοῦ χαλινοῦ; NI. ἀληθῆ. ΣΩ. οὐκοῦν ἐνὶ λόγῳ, ὅταν τίς τι ἔνεκά του σκοπῇ, περὶ ἐκείνου ἢ βουλή τυγχάνει οὕσα οὗ ἔνεκα ἐσκόπει, ἀλλ' οὐ περὶ τοῦ ὃ ἔνεκα ἄλλου ἐζήτει. NI. ἀνάγκη. ΣΩ. δεῖ ἄρα καὶ τὸν σύμβουλον σκοπεῖν ἄρα τεχνικὸς ἔστιν εἰς ἐκείνου θεραπείαν, οὗ ἔνεκα σκοποῦμενοι σκοποῦμεν. NI. πάνυ γε.

**NI:** It is about his eyes.

**S:** And when someone is considering a bridle for a horse, and whether it should be attached or not, and when this should happen, presumably he is then deliberating about the horse, and not about the bridle.

**NI:** True.

**S:** So, in a word, whenever someone considers something for the sake of something else, his deliberation is actually about that other thing. His deliberation is not concerned with whatever he was considering for the sake of that other thing.

**NI:** Necessarily.

**S:** So, we should consider whether the advisor is skilled in attending to that, namely to that for the sake of which we are engaging in these considerations.

**NI:** Certainly.

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**S:** So, at present we claim to be considering a subject for the sake of the souls of the young men, do we not?

ΣΩ. οὐκοῦν νῦν φαμεν περὶ μαθήματος σκοπεῖν τῆς ψυχῆς ἕνεκα τῆς τῶν νεανίσκων; ΝΙ. ναί. ΣΩ. εἴ τις ἄρα ἡμῶν τεχνικὸς περὶ ψυχῆς θεραπείαν καὶ οἷός τε καλῶς τοῦτο θεραπεῦσαι, καὶ ὅτῳ διδάσκαλοι ἀγαθοὶ γεγόνασιν, τοῦτο σκεπτέον. ΛΑ. τί δέ, ὦ Σώκρατες; οὐπω ἑώρακας ἄνευ διδασκάλων τεχνικωτέρους γεγονότας εἰς ἕνια ἢ μετὰ διδασκάλων; ΣΩ. ἔγωγε, ὦ Λάχης· οἷς γε σὺ οὐκ ἂν ἐθέλοις πιστεῦσαι, εἰ φαῖεν ἀγαθοὶ εἶναι δημιουργοί, εἰ μὴ τί σοι τῆς αὐτῶν τέχνης ἔργον ἔχοιεν ἐπιδειξάει εἰς εἰργασμένον, καὶ ἐν καὶ πλείω.

**NI:** Yes.

**S:** So we should consider if there is anyone among us who is skilled in attending to the soul, and is able to attend to it aright, and if there is anyone who has had good teachers?

**LA:** What's this, Socrates? Have you not noticed that in some cases people have become more skilled without teachers than with teachers?

**S:** I have, Laches, but you would not be prepared to believe them if they claimed to be good practitioners unless they were able to present you with one or more well-executed deeds, born of their own skill, as evidence.

**LA:** There you speak the truth.

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**S:** So, Nicias and Laches, since Lysimachus and Melesias have called upon us to advise them about their two sons, being eager that their souls turn out as excellent as they possibly can, we, if we claim to have teachers, should show them the ones who are themselves good in the first place, and have attended to the souls of many young men, and secondly, have evidently given instruction to ourselves. Alternatively, if any one of us declares that he himself has not had a teacher but can recount some deeds of his own, then he should point out any Athenians or strangers, slaves or free men, who are generally acknowledged to have become good through his agency. But if none of this applies to us, we should bid them look for someone else, and not run the risk of corrupting the sons of our companions and incurring enormous reproach from our closest kin. Now, Lysimachus and Melesias, I am the first to admit that I myself have not had a teacher of this, even though I set my heart on the matter from my earliest years. But I cannot afford to pay money to the sophists, the only people who proclaimed that they could make me noble and good, and I am unable, to this day, to discover the skill for myself. Yet I would not be surprised if Nicias or Laches have discovered it or learned it. In fact, they are wealthier than I am, and so they may have learned from others, and indeed they are older, so they may have discovered it already. Now, I think they are able to educate a person, for they would never have expressed their views so fearlessly on the pursuits that are useful or harmful for the young unless they were convinced that they had

sufficient knowledge. And although in general I believe them, I was surprised that they disagreed with one another. So, Lysimachus, I ask this of you in return. Just as Laches directed you a moment ago not to let me go, but to question me, I am now recommending that you do not let Laches and Nicias go, but ask them this question. Socrates denies that he has any knowledge of this matter, or that he is competent to decide which of you is speaking the truth, for he has neither discovered this sort of thing nor learned about it from anyone else. So, Nicias and Laches, you should tell us who is the most formidable person you have consulted in relation to the rearing of your sons; whether you are knowledgeable because you learned from someone else, or because you found out for yourselves; and if you did learn it, who were your teachers and who else has the same skill they have? We ask this in case you are too busy with affairs of state, in which case we could go to these people and persuade them, with gifts or favours or both, to take charge of our children, and yours too, so that they do not turn out badly and bring shame upon their ancestors. But if you have discovered this sort of thing yourselves, give us an example of some people whom you have already made good and noble through your care when they had previously been bad. For if you are now about to educate people for the first time, you should be careful lest you run risks, not with some worthless person, but with your own sons and the children of your friends, and simply end up, as the saying goes, practising pottery on too large a vessel. So, tell us which of these applies to you, and is appropriate in your case, and which is not. Find this out from them, Lysimachus, and do not let these men off.

ΛΑ. τοῦτο μὲν ἀληθὴ λέγεις. ΣΩ. καὶ ἡμᾶς ἄρα δεῖ, ὦ Λάχης τε καὶ Νικία —ἐπειδὴ Λυσίμαχος καὶ Μελησίας εἰς συμβουλήν παρεκαλεσάτην ἡμᾶς περὶ τοῖν ὑέοιν, προθυμούμενοι αὐτοῖν ὅτι ἀρίστas γενέσθαι τὰς ψυχὰς —εἰ μὲν φαμεν ἔχειν, ἐπιδειῖξαι αὐτοῖς καὶ διδασκάλους οἵτινες ἡμῶν γεγόνασιν αὐτοὶ πρῶτον ἀγαθοὶ ὄντες καὶ πολλῶν νέων τεθεραπευκότες ψυχὰς ἔπειτα καὶ ἡμᾶς διδάξαντες φαίνονται· ἢ εἴ τις ἡμῶν αὐτῶν ἑαυτῷ διδάσκαλον μὲν οὐ φησι γεγονέναι, ἀλλ' οὖν ἔργα

αὐτὸν αὐτοῦ ἔχειν εἰπεῖν καὶ ἐπιδείξαι τίνες Ἀθηναίων ἢ τῶν ξένων, ἢ δοῦλοι ἢ ἐλεύθεροι, δι' ἐκείνον ὁμολογουμένως ἀγαθοὶ γεγόνασιν· εἰ δὲ μηδὲν ἡμῖν τούτων ὑπάρχει, ἄλλους κελεύειν ζητεῖν καὶ μὴ ἐν ἐταίρων ἀνδρῶν ὑέσιν κινδυνεύειν διαφθείροντας τὴν μεγίστην αἰτίαν ἔχειν ὑπὸ τῶν οἰκειοτάτων. ἐγὼ μὲν οὖν, ὦ Λυσίμαχε τε καὶ Μελησία, πρῶτος περὶ ἑμαυτοῦ λέγω ὅτι διδάσκαλός μοι οὐ γέγονε τούτου πέρι. καίτοι ἐπιθυμῶ γε τοῦ πράγματος ἐκ νέου ἀρξάμενος. ἀλλὰ τοῖς μὲν σοφισταῖς οὐκ ἔχω τελεῖν μισθούς, οἵπερ μόνον ἐπηγγέλλοντό με οἰοί τ' εἶναι ποιῆσαι καλὸν τε κάγαθόν· αὐτὸς δ' αὖ εὗρεῖν τὴν τέχνην ἀδυνατῶ ἔτι νυνί. εἰ δὲ Νικίας ἢ Λάχης ἠύρηκεν ἢ μεμάθηκεν, οὐκ ἂν θαυμάσαιμι· καὶ γὰρ χρήμασιν ἐμοῦ δυνατώτεροι, ὥστε μαθεῖν παρ' ἄλλων, καὶ ἅμα πρεσβύτεροι, ὥστε ἤδη ἠύρηκέναι. δοκοῦσι δὴ μοι δυνατοὶ εἶναι παιδεῦσαι ἄνθρωπον· οὐ γὰρ ἂν ποτε ἀδεῶς ἀπεφάνοντο περὶ ἐπιτηδευμάτων νέῳ χρηστῶν τε καὶ πονηρῶν, εἰ μὴ αὐτοῖς ἐπίστευον ἱκανῶς εἰδέναι. τὰ μὲν οὖν ἄλλα ἔγωγε τούτοις πιστεύω· ὅτι δὲ διαφέρεσθον ἀλλήλοισιν, ἐθαύμασα. τοῦτο οὖν σου ἐγὼ ἀντιδέομαι, ὦ Λυσίμαχε· καθάπερ ἄρτι Λάχης μὴ ἀφίεσθαί σε ἐμοῦ διεκελεύετο ἀλλὰ ἐρωτᾶν, καὶ ἐγὼ νῦν παρακελεύομαί σοι μὴ ἀφίεσθαι Λάχητος μηδὲ Νικίου, ἀλλ' ἐρωτᾶν λέγοντα ὅτι ὁ μὲν Σωκράτης οὐ φησιν ἐπαῖειν περὶ τοῦ πράγματος οὐδ' ἱκανὸς εἶναι διακρίναι ὁπότερος ὑμῶν ἀληθὴ λέγει —οὔτε γὰρ εὐρετῆς οὔτε μαθητῆς οὐδενὸς περὶ τῶν τοιούτων γεγονέναι— ΣΩ. σὺ δ', ὦ Λάχης καὶ Νικία, εἶπετον ἡμῖν ἑκάτερος τί νῦν δεινотάτῳ συγγεγόνατον περὶ τῆς τῶν νέων τροφῆς, καὶ πότερα μαθόντε παρὰ τοῦ ἐπίστασθον ἢ αὐτῷ ἐξευρόντε, καὶ εἰ μὲν μαθόντε, τίς ὁ διδάσκαλος ἐκατέρῳ καὶ τίνες ἄλλοι ὁμότεχνοι αὐτοῖς, ἴν', ἂν μὴ ὑμῖν σχολὴ ἦ ὑπὸ τῶν τῆς πόλεως πραγμάτων, ἐπ' ἐκείνους ἴωμεν καὶ πείθωμεν ἢ δώροισιν ἢ χάρισιν ἢ ἀμφοτέρα ἐπιμεληθῆναι καὶ τῶν ἡμετέρων καὶ τῶν ὑμετέρων παίδων, ὅπως μὴ κατασχύνωσι τοὺς αὐτῶν προγόνους φαῦλοι γενόμενοι· εἰ δ' αὐτοὶ εὕρεται γεγονότε τοῦ τοιούτου, δότε παράδειγμα τίνων ἤδη ἄλλων ἐπιμεληθέντες ἐκ φαύλων καλοὺς τε κάγαθους ἐποιήσατε. εἰ γὰρ νῦν πρῶτον ἄρξεσθε παιδεύειν, σκοπεῖν χρή μὴ οὐκ ἐν τῷ Καρὶ ὑμῖν ὁ κίνδυνος κινδυνεύηται, ἀλλ' ἐν τοῖς ὑέσι τε καὶ ἐν τοῖς τῶν φίλων παισὶ, καὶ

ἀτεχνῶς τὸ λεγόμενον κατὰ τὴν παροιμίαν ὑμῖν συμβαίνειν ἐν πίσῳ ἢ κεραμείᾳ γιγνομένη. λέγετε οὖν τί τούτων ἢ φατὲ ὑμῖν ὑπάρχειν τε καὶ προσήκειν ἢ οὐ φατε. ταῦτ', ὦ Λυσίμαχε, παρ' αὐτῶν πυνθάνου τε καὶ μὴ μεθίει τοὺς ἄνδρας. ΛΥ. καλῶς μὲν ἔμοιγε δοκεῖ, ὦ ἄνδρες, Σωκράτης λέγειν·

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**LY:** Gentlemen, although Socrates has, in my opinion, spoken well, you, Nicias and Laches, should decide for yourselves whether you wish to be questioned on such matters and give an account of them. Now, Melesias and myself would, of course, be delighted if you were willing to give a full response to everything that Socrates asked. In fact, I said at the very outset that we were going to invite you to advise us on this issue because we thought you were likely to care about this sort of thing, especially since your own children, just like ours, are almost of an age to be educated. So, if it makes no difference to you, speak, and consider this, along with Socrates, in the give and take of discourse with one another. For his point is well made; we are now deliberating about our most important possessions. So take a look and decide if this is what should be done.

εἰ δὲ βουλομένοις ὑμῖν ἐστὶ περὶ τῶν τοιούτων ἐρωτᾶσθαί τε καὶ διδόναι λόγον, αὐτοὺς δὴ χρὴ γινώσκειν, ὦ Νικία τε καὶ Λάχης. ἐμοὶ μὲν γὰρ καὶ Μελησίᾳ τῷδε δῆλον ὅτι ἡδομένοις ἂν εἴη εἰ πάντα ἃ Σωκράτης ἐρωτᾷ ἐθέλοιτε λόγῳ διεξιέναι· καὶ γὰρ ἐξ ἀρχῆς ἐντεῦθεν ἡρχόμεν λέγων, ὅτι εἰς συμβουλήν διὰ ταῦτα ὑμᾶς παρακαλέσαιμεν, ὅτι μεμεληκέναι ὑμῖν ἡγούμεθα, ὡς εἰκός, περὶ τῶν τοιούτων, καὶ ἄλλως καὶ ἐπειδὴ οἱ παῖδες ὑμῖν ὀλίγου ὥσπερ οἱ ἡμέτεροι ἡλικίαν ἔχουσι παιδεύεσθαι. εἰ οὖν ὑμῖν μὴ τι διαφέρει, εἵπατε καὶ κοινῇ μετὰ Σωκράτους σκέψασθε, διδόντες τε καὶ δεχόμενοι λόγον παρ' ἀλλήλων· εὖ γὰρ καὶ τοῦτο λέγει ὁδε, ὅτι περὶ τοῦ μεγίστου νῦν βουλευόμεθα τῶν ἡμετέρων. ἀλλ' ὁρᾶτε εἰ δοκεῖ χρῆναι οὕτω ποιεῖν. ΝΙ. ὦ Λυσίμαχε, δοκεῖς μοι ὡς ἀληθῶς Σωκράτη πατρόθεν γινώσκειν μόνον, αὐτῷ δ' οὐ συγγεγονέναι ἀλλ' ἢ

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**NI:** Lysimachus, you seem to me, in truth, to know Socrates only through his father, and not to have associated with the man himself except when he was a child, when you came across him among the local people, as he accompanied his father to the temple or some other public gathering. But it is obvious that you are still unacquainted with the man in his mature years.

παιδὶ ὄντι, εἴ που ἐν τοῖς δημόταις μετὰ τοῦ πατρὸς ἀκολουθῶν ἐπλησίασέν σοι ἢ ἐν ἱερῷ ἢ ἐν ἄλλῳ τῷ συλλόγῳ τῶν δημοτῶν· ἐπειδὴ δὲ πρεσβύτερος γέγονεν, οὐκ ἐντετυχηκῶς τῷ ἀνδρὶ δῆλος ἔτι εἶ. ΛΥ. τί μάλιστα, ὦ Νικία; ΝΙ. οὐ μοι δοκεῖς εἰδέναι ὅτι ὃς ἂν ἐγγύτατα Σωκράτους ἦ λόγῳ ὥσπερ γένει καὶ πλησιάξῃ διαλεγόμενος, ἀνάγκη αὐτῷ, ἐὰν ἄρα καὶ περὶ ἄλλου του πρότερον ἄρξηται διαλέγεσθαι, μὴ παύεσθαι ὑπὸ τούτου περιηγόμενον τῷ λόγῳ, πρὶν ἂν ἐμπέσῃ εἰς τὸ διδόναι περὶ αὐτοῦ λόγον, ὅντινα τρόπον νῦν τε ζῇ καὶ ὄντινα τὸν παρεληλυθότα βίον βεβίωκεν· ἐπειδὴ δ' ἐμπέσῃ, ὅτι οὐ πρότερον αὐτὸν ἀφήσει Σωκράτης, πρὶν ἂν βασανίσῃ ταῦτα εὖ τε καὶ καλῶς ἅπαντα. ἐγὼ δὲ συνήθης τέ εἰμι τῷδε καὶ οἷδ' ὅτι ἀνάγκη ὑπὸ τούτου πάσχειν ταῦτα, καὶ ἔτι γε αὐτὸς ὅτι πείσομαι ταῦτα εὖ οἷδα· χαίρω γάρ, ὦ Λυσίμαχε, τῷ ἀνδρὶ πλησιάζων, καὶ οὐδὲν οἶμαι κακὸν εἶναι τὸ ὑπομιμνήσκεσθαι ὅτι μὴ καλῶς ἢ πεποιήκαμεν ἢ ποιοῦμεν, ἀλλ' εἰς τὸν ἔπειτα βίον προμηθέστερον ἀνάγκη εἶναι τὸν ταῦτα μὴ φεύγοντα ἀλλ' ἐθέλοντα κατὰ τὸ τοῦ Σόλωνος καὶ ἀξιοῦντα μανθάνειν ἕωσπερ ἂν ζῇ, καὶ μὴ οἰόμενον αὐτῷ τὸ γῆρας νοῦν ἔχον προσιέναι. ἐμοὶ μὲν οὖν οὐδὲν ἄηθες οὐδ' αὖ ἡδὺς ὑπὸ Σωκράτους βασανίζεσθαι, ἀλλὰ καὶ πάλαι σχεδόν τι ἡπιστάμην ὅτι οὐ περὶ τῶν μεираκίων ἡμῖν ὁ λόγος ἔσοιτο Σωκράτους παρόντος, ἀλλὰ περὶ

**LY:** What makes you so sure, Nicias?

**NI:** You seem to me to be unaware that whoever gets close to Socrates and engages in a dialogue with him must necessarily, even if he starts off by discussing something else at first, be led around by this man relentlessly in the discussion until he submits to giving an account of himself, the manner in which he is living his life at present, and how

he has lived his life until now. And once he submits, Socrates will not let him go until he tests all this, well and truly. Now, I am used to him, and I know that it is necessary to undergo this process at his hands, and yet I know quite well that I too shall undergo this. Indeed, Lysimachus, I delight in engaging with the man, and I think there is no harm in being made aware that we have acted, or are acting, badly. Rather, a person who does not flee from these processes, but willingly embraces the maxim of Solon, and values learning for as long as he lives and does not presume that old age of itself brings good sense, he must necessarily be more careful about the rest of his life. For me, there is nothing strange or unpleasant in being tested by Socrates. I more or less knew a while ago that with Socrates present the conversation would not be about our sons, but about ourselves. So, as I say, there is no reason for me not to converse with Socrates in whatever way he wishes. But you should see where Laches here stands on the matter.

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**LA:** Nicias, my attitude to discussions is simple, or if you prefer, not simple, but twofold. In fact, someone might think me a lover of discourse, and then again a hater of discourse. For whenever I hear a man discoursing on the subject of excellence or any sort of wisdom, a true man who is worthy of the words he is speaking, I am delighted beyond measure when I see that both the speaker and the words spoken are mutually appropriate and in harmony. And such a person seems genuinely musical to me, attuned to the noblest harmony, not of a lyre or instruments of entertainment, but in truth he makes his own life a concord of words with deeds, attuned not, I believe, to the Ionic mode, nor to the Phrygian nor the Lydian, but to the Doric mode, which is the only harmony that is indeed Greek. When a man like this speaks, he makes me happy, and anyone would think me a lover of discourse because I accept what the man says so eagerly. But someone who behaves in the opposite way pains me, and the better he seems to speak, the greater the pain, and he makes me seem, in turn, to be a hater of discourse. Now, I'm not acquainted with Socrates' words, but it

seems that I do have previous experience of his deeds, and therein I found him worthy of noble words and total freedom of speech. So, if he also has this quality, we are like-minded, and I would gladly submit to scrutiny by such a man as this, and would not be reluctant to learn from him, since I too agree with that precept of Solon, with just one reservation: I am willing to grow old, learning a lot in the process, but only from worthy men. Let Solon concede this point to me, that my teacher should also be good, so that I do not turn out to be a difficult pupil with a distaste for learning. But if my teacher is to be younger than I am, or is not yet famous or has some other shortcoming of that kind, that does not concern me. So, Socrates, I invite you to teach me and refute me in whatever way you please, and also to learn, in turn, anything that I know, such is the regard I have for you ever since that day when you were my companion in danger and gave proof of your own excellence – the sort that a man who intends to do justice to himself ought to give. So say anything you like and do not take account of our age difference.

ἡμῶν αὐτῶν. ὅπερ οὖν λέγω, τὸ μὲν ἑμὸν οὐδὲν κωλύει Σωκράτει συνδιατρίβειν ὅπως οὗτος βούλεται· Λάχητα δὲ τόνδε ὅρα ὅπως ἔχει περὶ τοῦ τοιούτου. ΛΑ. ἀπλοῦν τό γ' ἑμόν, ὧ Νικία, περὶ λόγων ἐστίν, εἰ δὲ βούλει, οὐχ ἀπλοῦν ἀλλὰ διπλοῦν· καὶ γὰρ ἂν δόξαιμί τῳ φιλόλογος εἶναι καὶ αὖ μισόλογος. ὅταν μὲν γὰρ ἀκούω ἀνδρὸς περὶ ἀρετῆς διαλεγομένου ἢ περὶ τίνος σοφίας ὡς ἀληθῶς ὄντος ἀνδρὸς καὶ ἀξίου τῶν λόγων ὧν λέγει, χαίρω ὑπερφυῶς, θεώμενος ἅμα τὸν τε λέγοντα καὶ τὰ λεγόμενα ὅτι πρόποντα ἀλλήλοις καὶ ἀρμόττοντά ἐστι. καὶ κομιδῇ μοι δοκεῖ μουσικὸς ὁ τοιοῦτος εἶναι, ἀρμονίαν καλλίστην ἡρμοσμένος οὐ λύραν οὐδὲ παιδιᾶς ὄργανα, ἀλλὰ τῷ ὄντι ζῆν ἡρμοσμένος οὗ αὐτὸς αὐτοῦ τὸν βίον σύμφωνον τοῖς λόγοις πρὸς τὰ ἔργα, ἀτεχνῶς δωριστί· ἀλλ' οὐκ ἰαστί, οἶομαι δὲ οὐδὲ φρυγιστί οὐδὲ λυδιστί, ἀλλ' ἤπερ μόνῃ Ἑλληνικῇ ἐστὶν ἀρμονία. ὁ μὲν οὖν τοιοῦτος χαίρειν με ποιεῖ φθεγγόμενος καὶ δοκεῖν ὀτρωοῦν φιλόλογον εἶναι—οὕτω σφόδρα ἀποδέχομαι παρ' αὐτοῦ τὰ λεγόμενα—ὁ δὲ τάναντία τούτου πράττων λυπεῖ με, ὅσῳ ἂν δοκῇ ἄμεινον λέγειν, τοσοῦτῳ

μᾶλλον, καὶ ποιεῖ αὐτὸ δοκεῖν εἶναι μισόλογον. ΛΑ. Σωκράτους δ' ἐγὼ τῶν μὲν λόγων οὐκ ἔμπειρός εἰμι, ἀλλὰ πρότερον, ὥς ἔοικε, τῶν ἔργων ἐπειράθην, καὶ ἐκεῖ αὐτόν

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**S:** It seems we cannot accuse you two of being reluctant to give advice and join our enquiry.

ἡῦρον ἄξιον ὄντα λόγων καλῶν καὶ πάσης παρρησίας. εἰ οὖν καὶ τοῦτο ἔχει, συμβούλομαι τάνδρι, καὶ ἥδιστ' ἂν ἐξεταζοίμην ὑπὸ τοῦ τοιούτου, καὶ οὐκ ἂν ἀχθοίμην μανθάνων, ἀλλὰ καὶ ἐγὼ τῷ Σόλωνι, ἐν μόνον προσλαβὼν, συγχωρῶ· γηράσκων γὰρ πολλὰ διδάσκεσθαι ἐθέλω ὑπὸ χρηστῶν μόνον. τοῦτο γάρ μοι συγχωρεῖτω, ἀγαθὸν καὶ αὐτὸν εἶναι τὸν διδάσκαλον, ἵνα μὴ δυσμαθὴς φαίνωμαι ἀηδῶς μανθάνων· εἰ δὲ νεώτερος ὁ διδάσκων ἔσται ἢ μήπω ἐν δόξῃ ὦν ἤ τι

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**LY:** But it's our work you are doing, Socrates, for I count you as one of us, so take my place on behalf of the young men and make the enquiry. Find out whatever we need to know from these gentlemen, and then act as our adviser by discussing it with the boys. For I am inclined nowadays, because of my age, to forget for the most part the questions I intend to ask, and any answers too, and if other arguments are introduced during the process my memory goes completely, so you should do the talking. Go through the issues we are interested in among yourselves. I shall listen in, and then I, along with Melesias here, shall do whatever you suggest.

ἄλλο τῶν τοιούτων ἔχων, οὐδὲν μοι μέλει. σοὶ οὖν, ὦ Σώκρατες, ἐγὼ ἐπαγγέλλομαι καὶ διδάσκειν καὶ ἐλέγχειν ἐμὲ ὅτι ἂν βούλῃ, καὶ μανθάνειν γε ὅτι αὐτὸ ἐγὼ οἶδα οὕτω σὺ παρ' ἐμοὶ διάκεισαι ἀπ' ἐκείνης τῆς ἡμέρας ἥ μετ' ἐμοῦ συνδιεκινδύνευσας καὶ ἔδωκας σαυτοῦ πείραν ἀρετῆς ἣν χρή διδόναι τὸν μέλλοντα δικαίως δώσειν. λέγ' οὖν ὅτι σοι φίλον, μηδὲν τὴν ἡμετέραν ἡλικίαν ὑπόλογον ποιούμενος.

189c

**S:** Nicias and Laches, we should comply with this request of Lysimachus and Melesias. Now, a moment ago we set about considering what instructors we have had in this kind of education, and what other people we have made better. Perhaps we would do well to investigate such questions ourselves. But I think the following enquiry leads to the same thing, and to an extent it proceeds more from principle. So if we happen to know, in relation to anything at all, that its presence in something makes that in which it is present better, and furthermore we are able to make it be present in that, it is obvious that we know the thing itself, that's the matter on which we would be acting as advisers on how it might best and most easily be acquired. Perhaps you do not understand what I am saying, but you shall understand more easily from the following. If we happen to know that if sight is present to the eyes it makes those eyes in which it is present better, and if we are also able to make it present in eyes, it is obvious that we know exactly what sight is. And sight is the subject on which we would be acting as advisers on how it might best and most easily be acquired. For if we did not know what exactly sight itself was, or hearing either, we could hardly act as worthy advisers and physicians in relation to eyes or ears, and the manner in which someone might best acquire hearing or sight.

ΣΩ. οὐ τὰ ὑμέτερα, ὡς ἔοικεν, αἰτιασόμεθα μὴ οὐχ ἔτοιμα εἶναι καὶ συμβουλεύειν καὶ συσκοπεῖν. ΛΥ. ἀλλ' ἡμέτερον δὴ ἔργον, ὦ Σώκρατες—ἓνα γάρ σε ἔγωγε ἡμῶν τίθημι—σκοπεῖ οὖν ἀντ' ἐμοῦ ὑπὲρ τῶν νεανίσκων ὅτι δεόμεθα παρὰ τῶνδε πυθάνεσθαι, καὶ συμβούλευε διαλεγόμενος τούτοις. ἐγὼ μὲν γὰρ καὶ ἐπιλανθάνομαι ἤδη τὰ πολλὰ διὰ τὴν ἡλικίαν ὣν ἂν διανοηθῶ ἐρέσθαι καὶ αὐτὸν ἂν ἀκούσω· ἐὰν δὲ μεταξὺ ἄλλοι λόγοι γένωνται, οὐ πάνυ μένημαι. ὑμεῖς οὖν λέγετε καὶ διέξίτε πρὸς ὑμᾶς αὐτοὺς περὶ ὧν προυθέμεθα· ἐγὼ δ' ἀκούσομαι καὶ ἀκούσας αὐτὰ μετὰ Μελησίου τοῦδε ποιήσω τοῦτο ὅτι ἂν καὶ ὑμῖν δοκῇ. ΣΩ. πειστέον, ὦ Νικία τε καὶ Λάχης, Λυσιμάχῳ καὶ Μελησίᾳ. ἃ μὲν οὖν νυνδὴ ἐπεχειρήσαμεν σκοπεῖν, τίνες οἱ διδάσκαλοι ἡμῖν τῆς τοιαύτης παιδείας γεγόνασιν ἢ τίνας ἄλλους βελτίους πεποιθήκαμεν, ἴσως μὲν οὐ

κακῶς εἶχεν ἐξετάζειν καὶ τὰ τοιαῦτα ἡμᾶς αὐτούς· ἀλλ' οἶμαι καὶ ἡ τοιάδε σκέψις εἰς ταὐτὸν φέρει, σχεδὸν δέ τι καὶ μᾶλλον ἐξ ἀρχῆς εἴη ἄν. εἰ γὰρ τυγχάνομεν ἐπιστάμενοι ὅτουοῦν πέρι ὅτι παραγενόμενόν τῳ βέλτιον ποιεῖ ἐκεῖνο ὃ παρεγένετο, καὶ προσέτι οἱοί τέ ἐσμεν αὐτὸ ποιεῖν παραγίγνεσθαι ἐκεῖνον, δῆλον ὅτι αὐτὸ γε ἴσμεν τοῦτο οὐ πέρι σύμβουλοι ἂν γενοίμεθα ὡς ἂν τις αὐτὸ ῥᾶστα καὶ ἄριστ' ἂν κτήσαιο. ἴσως οὖν οὐ μανθάνετε μου ὅτι λέγω, ἀλλ' ὥδε ῥᾶον μαθήσεσθε. ΣΩ. εἰ τυγχάνομεν ἐπιστάμενοι ὅτι ὄψις παραγενομένη ὀφθαλμοῖς βελτίους ποιεῖ ἐκείνους οἷς παρεγένετο, καὶ προσέτι οἱοί τ' ἐσμεν ποιεῖν αὐτὴν παραγίγνεσθαι ὁμμασι, δῆλον ὅτι ὄψιν γε ἴσμεν αὐτὴν ὅτι ποτ' ἔστιν, ἥς πέρι σύμβουλοι ἂν γενοίμεθα ὡς ἂν τις αὐτὴν ῥᾶστα καὶ ἄριστα κτήσαιο. εἰ γὰρ μὴδ' αὐτὸ τοῦτο εἰδεῖμεν, ὅτι ποτ' ἔστιν ὄψις ἢ ὅτι ἔστιν ἀκοή, σχολῇ ἂν σύμβουλοί γε ἄξιοι λόγου γενοίμεθα καὶ ἱατροῖ ἢ περὶ ὀφθαλμῶν ἢ περὶ ὧτων, ὄντινα τρόπον

190b

**LA:** That's true, Socrates

ἀκοὴν ἢ ὄψιν κάλλιστ' ἂν κτήσαιο τις. ΛΑ. ἀληθῇ λέγεις, ὦ Σώκρατες. ΣΩ. οὐκοῦν, ὦ Λάχης, καὶ νῦν ἡμᾶς τῷδε παρακαλεῖτον εἰς συμβουλήν, τίς ἂν τρόπον τοῖς υἱέσιν αὐτῶν ἀρετὴ παραγενομένη ταῖς ψυχαῖς ἀμείνους ποιήσῃ; ΛΑ. πάνυ γε. ΣΩ. ἄρ' οὖν ἡμῖν τοῦτό γ' ὑπάρχειν δεῖ, τὸ εἰδέναι ὅτι ποτ' ἔστιν ἀρετή; εἰ γὰρ που μὴδ' ἀρετὴν εἰδεῖμεν τὸ παράπαν ὅτι ποτε τυγχάνει ὄν, τίς ἂν τρόπον τούτου

**S:** Well, Laches, are there not two men now inviting us to counsel them on the manner in which their sons may be made better by the presence of excellence in their souls?

**LA:** Certainly.

**S:** Well then, the first thing we need is this. We need to know what precisely excellence is, do we not? For if, somehow, we were totally ignorant as to what precisely excellence happens to be, how could we act as advisers to anyone on how it may best be acquired?

190c

**LA:** I don't think we could do so at all, Socrates.

σύμβουλοι γενοίμεθ' ἂν ὁπωοῦν, ὅπως ἂν αὐτὸ κάλλιστα κτήσαιοτο; ΛΑ. οὐδένα, ἔμοιγε δοκεῖ, ὦ Σώκρατες. ΣΩ. φαμέν ἄρα, ὦ Λάχης, εἰδέναι αὐτὸ ὅτι ἔστιν. ΛΑ. φαμέν μέντοι. ΣΩ. οὐκοῦν ὃ γε ἴσμεν, κὰν εἴποιμεν δήπου τί ἐστιν. ΛΑ. πῶς γὰρ οὐ; ΣΩ. μὴ τοίνυν, ὦ ἄριστε, περὶ ὅλης ἀρετῆς εὐθέως σκοπώμεθα—πλέον γὰρ ἴσως ἔργον—ἀλλὰ μέρους τινὸς περὶ πρῶτον ἴδωμεν εἰ ἰκανῶς ἔχομεν πρὸς τὸ εἰδέναι· καὶ

**S:** However, we do say that we know what it is, Laches.

**LA:** Yes, we say so.

**S:** And in the case of what we know, we could of course also, surely, say what it is.

**LA:** Of course.

**S:** Well, excellent man, let us not consider excellence as a whole straight away, since that task is probably beyond us. But let us first see if we have sufficient knowledge of some part of it. Then the enquiry will, in all likelihood, be easier for us.

190d

**LA:** Then let us do as you suggest, Socrates.

ἡμῖν, ὥς τὸ εἰκός, ῥάων ἢ σκέψις ἔσται. ΛΑ. ἀλλ' οὕτω ποιῶμεν, ὦ Σώκρατες, ὥς σὺ βούλει. ΣΩ. τί οὖν ἂν προελοίμεθα τῶν τῆς ἀρετῆς μερῶν; ἢ δῆλον δὴ ὅτι τοῦτο εἰς ὃ τείνειν δοκεῖ ἢ ἐν τοῖς ὅπλοις μάθησις; δοκεῖ δέ που τοῖς πολλοῖς εἰς ἀνδρείαν. ἢ γάρ; ΛΑ. καὶ μάλα δὴ οὕτω δοκεῖ. ΣΩ. τοῦτο τοίνυν πρῶτον ἐπιχειρήσωμεν, ὦ Λάχης, εἰπεῖν, ἀνδρεία τί ποτ' ἐστίν· ἔπειτα μετὰ τοῦτο σκεψόμεθα

**S:** So, which of the parts of excellence should we choose? Or is it obviously the one that learning how to fight in armour seems to promote? And most people presumably think it promotes courage. Is this so?

**LA:** Yes, indeed, very much so.

190e

**S:** In that case, Laches, we should first attempt to state what exactly courage is. Then, after that, we shall also consider the manner in which it may become present in young people, insofar as it can become present through the pursuits they engage in and the subjects they learn. So, as I say, try to state what courage is.

καὶ ὅτῳ ἂν τρόπῳ τοῖς νεανίσκοις παραγένοιτο, καθ' ὅσον οἷόν τε ἐξ ἐπιτηδευμάτων τε καὶ μαθημάτων παραγενέσθαι. ἀλλὰ πειρῶ εἰπεῖν ὃ λέγω, τί ἐστὶν ἀνδρεία. ΛΑ. οὐ μὰ τὸν Δία, ὦ Σώκρατες, οὐ χαλεπὸν εἰπεῖν· εἰ γάρ τις ἐθέλοι ἐν τῇ τάξει μένων ἀμύνεσθαι τοὺς πολεμίους καὶ μὴ φεύγει, εὖ ἴσθι ὅτι ἀνδρεῖος ἂν εἴη. ΣΩ. εὖ μὲν λέγεις, ὦ Λάχης· ἀλλ' ἴσως ἐγὼ αἴτιος, οὐ σαφῶς εἰπὼν, τὸ σὲ ἀποκρίνασθαι μὴ τοῦτο ὁ διανοούμενος ἠρόμην, ἀλλ' ἕτερον. ΛΑ. πῶς τοῦτο λέγεις, ὦ Σώκρατες;

**LA:** By Zeus, Socrates. There is no difficulty in stating that if someone were prepared to remain at his post, ward off the enemy and not run away, then mark my words, he would be courageous.

**S:** That is nicely put, Laches, and perhaps I am to blame for not expressing myself more clearly, but you have not answered the question I had in mind. You have answered a different one.

**LA:** What do you mean by this, Socrates?

191a

**S:** I shall tell you, if I can. Presumably that man is courageous, the one you describe, the one who remains at his post and fights the enemy.

ΣΩ. ἐγὼ φράσω, ἐὰν οἷός τε γένωμαι. ἀνδρεῖός που οὗτος, ὃν καὶ σὺ λέγεις, ὃς ἂν ἐν τῇ τάξει μένων μάχηται τοῖς πολεμίους. ΛΑ. ἐγὼ γοῦν φημι. ΣΩ. καὶ γὰρ ἐγώ. ἀλλὰ τί αὖ ὅδε, ὃς ἂν φεύγων μάχηται τοῖς πολεμίους ἀλλὰ μὴ μένων; ΛΑ. πῶς φεύγων; ΣΩ. ὥσπερ που καὶ Σκύθαι λέγονται οὐχ ἥττον φεύγοντες ἢ διώκοντες μάχεσθαι, καὶ Ὅμηρός που ἐπαινῶν τοὺς τοῦ Αἰνείου ἵππους κραιπνὰ μάλ' ἔνθα καὶ ἔνθα

**LA:** Yes, that's what I am saying.

**S:** And so am I. But what about someone who fights the enemy whilst fleeing rather than remaining at his post?

**LA:** Fleeing in what sense?

191b

**S:** Presumably in the sense that the Scythians are said to fight whilst fleeing, no less than they do in pursuit. And Homer, in praise of the horses of Aeneas, says that they knew how to pursue and also to flee very swiftly, hither and thither. And he praises Aeneas himself for his knowledge of flight, and he refers to him as a ‘counsellor of flight’.

ἔφη αὐτοὺς ἐπίστασθαι διώκειν ἢ δὲ φέβεσθαι· καὶ αὐτὸν τὸν Αἰνεΐαν κατὰ τοῦτ’ ἐνεκωμίασε, κατὰ τὴν τοῦ φόβου ἐπιστήμην, καὶ εἶπεν αὐτὸν εἶναι μῆστωρα φόβοιο. ΛΑ. καὶ καλῶς γε, ὦ Σώκρατες· περὶ ἀρμάτων γὰρ ἔλεγε. καὶ σὺ τὸ τῶν Σκυθῶν ἱππέων πέρι λέγεις· τὸ μὲν γὰρ ἱππικὸν τὸ ἐκείνων οὕτω μάχεται, τὸ δὲ ὀπλιτικὸν τό γε τῶν Ἑλλήνων, ὥς ἐγὼ λέγω. ΣΩ. πλὴν γ’ ἴσως, ὦ Λάχης, τὸ Λακεδαιμονίων. Λακεδαιμονίους

**LA:** And rightly so, Socrates, since he was referring to chariots, and you are talking about the Scythian horsemen. But although the cavalry fight in that way, the men at arms fight in the way I am describing.

191c

**S:** Except perhaps for the Spartans, Laches. Indeed, they say that when the Spartans at Plataea came across the men with the wicker shields, they were not willing to remain in position and do battle with them, so they fled. But once the Persian ranks had broken, they turned around and fought, just as horsemen do, and so won the battle of Plataea.

γάρ φασιν ἐν Πλαταιαῖς, ἐπειδὴ πρὸς τοῖς γεροφόροις ἐγένοντο, οὐκ ἐθέλιν μένοντας πρὸς αὐτοὺς μάχεσθαι, ἀλλὰ φεύγειν, ἐπειδὴ δ’ ἐλύθησαν αἱ τάξεις τῶν Περσῶν, ἀναστρεφομένους ὥσπερ ἱππέας μάχεσθαι καὶ οὕτω νικῆσαι τὴν ἐκεῖ μάχην. ΛΑ. ἀληθῆ λέγεις. ΣΩ. τοῦτο τοίνυν ὁ ἄρτι ἔλεγον, ὅτι ἐγὼ αἴτιος μὴ καλῶς σε ἀποκρίνασθαι, ὅτι οὐ καλῶς ἠρόμην—βουλόμενος

**LA:** That’s true.

**S:** Well, this is what I meant earlier, that I am responsible for the fact that you did not answer properly because I did not ask the question properly. Indeed, I wanted to find out from you not just who are courageous among the infantry, but also among the cavalry and the entire warrior class; and not only who are courageous in battle, but also amidst perils at sea; and who are courageous in the face of disease or poverty or political issues. And furthermore, I also wanted to find out who are courageous not only when faced with pain or fear, but also who are formidable at combatting desire or pleasure, either by standing firm or rallying against them. For I presume, Laches, there are some people who are courageous in such situations as these.

**LA:** Very much so, Socrates.

191d

**S:** So all these people are courageous, but some possess courage in the face of pleasures, others in the face of pain or desire or fear, while others I believe display cowardice in the same situations.

γάρ σου πυθέσθαι μὴ μόνον τοὺς ἐν τῷ ὀπλιτικῷ ἀνδρείους, ἀλλὰ καὶ τοὺς ἐν τῷ ἵππικῷ καὶ ἐν σύμπαντι τῷ πολεμικῷ εἶδει, καὶ μὴ μόνον τοὺς ἐν τῷ πολέμῳ, ἀλλὰ καὶ τοὺς ἐν τοῖς πρὸς τὴν θάλατταν κινδύνοις ἀνδρείους ὄντας, καὶ ὅσοι γε πρὸς νόσους καὶ ὅσοι πρὸς πενίας ἢ καὶ πρὸς τὰ πολιτικά ἀνδρεῖοί εἰσιν, καὶ ἔτι αὖ μὴ μόνον ὅσοι πρὸς λύπας ἀνδρεῖοί εἰσιν ἢ φόβους, ἀλλὰ καὶ πρὸς ἐπιθυμίας ἢ ἡδονὰς δεινοὶ

**LA:** Entirely so.

191e

**S:** What exactly are these two, courage and cowardice? That is what I wanted to find out. So try once more to state firstly what courage, which is the same in all these instances, actually is. Or do you not fully understand what I am saying yet?

μάχεσθαι, καὶ μένοντες καὶ ἀναστρέφοντες—εἰσὶ γάρ πού τινες, ὧς Λάχης, καὶ ἐν τοῖς τοιούτοις ἀνδρεῖοι— ΛΑ. καὶ σφόδρα, ὧς Σώκρατες. ΣΩ. οὐκοῦν ἀνδρεῖοι μὲν πάντες οὗτοί εἰσιν, ἀλλ' οἱ μὲν ἐν ἡδοναῖς, οἱ δ' ἐν λύπαις, οἱ δ' ἐν ἐπιθυμίαις, οἱ δ' ἐν φόβοις τὴν ἀνδρείαν κέκτηνται·

οἱ δέ γ' οἶμαι δειλίαν ἐν τοῖς αὐτοῖς τούτοις. ΛΑ. πάνυ γε. ΣΩ. τί ποτε ὄν ἐκάτερον τούτων; τοῦτο ἐπυνθανόμην. πάλιν οὖν πειρῶ εἰπεῖν ἀνδρείαν πρῶτον τί ὄν ἐν πᾶσι τούτοις ταυτόν ἐστιν· ἢ οὐπω καταμανθάνεις ὃ λέγω; ΛΑ. οὐ πάνυ τι.

**LA:** Not entirely.

**S:** What I mean is this. It is as if I were asking what exactly speed is, which we encounter in running, in harp-playing, in speaking, in learning – a quality we exhibit to an extent in any activity worth mentioning, of hands, legs or mouth, and in speech and thought too. Is this how you speak of it too?

**LA:** Very much so.

192a

**S:** Well, if someone were to ask me, “Socrates, what do you say this quality is, the one you refer to as speed in all these examples?” I would tell him that I call speed the power that gets a lot done in a short time, whether in speech or running or in anything else.

ΣΩ. ἀλλ' ὥδε λέγω, ὥσπερ ἂν εἰ τάχος ἡρώτων τί ποτ' ἐστίν, ὃ καὶ ἐν τῷ τρέχειν τυγχάνει ὄν ἡμῖν καὶ ἐν τῷ κιθαρίζειν καὶ ἐν τῷ λέγειν καὶ ἐν τῷ μανθάνειν καὶ ἐν ἄλλοις πολλοῖς, καὶ σχεδόν τι αὐτὸ κεκτήμεθα, οὗ καὶ περὶ ἄξιον λέγειν, ἢ ἐν ταῖς τῶν χειρῶν πράξεσιν ἢ σκελῶν ἢ στόματός τε καὶ φωνῆς ἢ διανοίας· ἢ οὐχ οὕτω καὶ σὺ λέγεις; ΛΑ. πάνυ γε. ΣΩ. εἰ τοίνυν τίς με ἔροιτο· ὦ Σώκρατες, τί λέγεις τοῦτο ὃ ἐν πᾶσιν ὀνομάζεις ταχυτήτα εἶναι; εἵποίμ' ἂν

**LA:** And you would be right to say so.

**S:** Now, Laches, you should also try to describe courage in this way. What power, the same in the case of pleasure and in the case of pain, and in all the other examples we gave a moment ago, is referred to as courage?

192b

**LA:** Well, it seems to me to be an endurance of the soul, if I must describe what naturally applies to them all.

αὐτῷ ὅτι τὴν ἐν ὀλίγῳ χρόνῳ πολλὰ διαπραττομένην δύναμιν ταχυτῆτα ἔγωγε καλῶ καὶ περὶ φωνήν καὶ περὶ δρόμον καὶ περὶ τᾶλλα πάντα. ΛΑ. ὀρθῶς γε σὺ λέγων. ΣΩ. πειρῶ δὴ καὶ σύ, ὦ Λάχης, τὴν ἀνδρείαν οὕτως εἰπεῖν τίς οὔσα δύναμις ἡ αὐτὴ ἐν ἡδονῇ καὶ ἐν λύπῃ καὶ ἐν ἅπασιν οἷς νυνδὴ ἐλέγομεν αὐτὴν εἶναι, ἔπειτα ἀνδρεία κέκληται. ΛΑ. δοκεῖ τοίνυν μοι καρτερία τις εἶναι τῆς ψυχῆς, εἰ

**S:** But of course we must, if we are to answer the question we put to ourselves. Yet it appears to me that you certainly do not, as I see it, regard all endurance as courage. I justify this assertion as follows: I know fairly well, Laches, that you count courage among the qualities that are utterly noble.

**LA:** Among the very noblest, rest assured.

192c

**S:** Is not endurance, accompanied by wisdom, good and noble?

τό γε διὰ πάντων περὶ ἀνδρείας πεφυκὸς δεῖ εἰπεῖν. ΣΩ. ἀλλὰ μὴν δεῖ, εἴ γε τὸ ἐρωτώμενον ἀποκρινόμεθα ἡμῖν αὐτοῖς. τοῦτο τοίνυν ἔμοιγε φαίνεται οὔτι πᾶσά γε, ὥς ἐγὼμαι, καρτερία ἀνδρεία σοι φαίνεται. τεκμαίρομαι δὲ ἐνθένδε· σχεδὸν γάρ τι οἶδα, ὦ Λάχης, ὅτι τῶν πάνυ καλῶν πραγμάτων ἡγῇ σὺ ἀνδρείαν εἶναι. ΛΑ. εὔ μὲν οὖν ἴσθι ὅτι τῶν καλλίστων. ΣΩ. οὐκοῦν ἢ μὲν μετὰ φρονήσεως καρτερία καλὴ κάγαθή; ΛΑ. πάνυ γε.

**LA:** Absolutely.

**S:** What if it is accompanied by ignorance? In that case, on the contrary, is it not harmful and damaging?

**LA:** Yes.

192d

**S:** Now, will you say that something like this is noble when it is damaging and harmful?

ΣΩ. τί δ' ἢ μετ' ἀφροσύνης; οὐ τὸυναντίον ταύτῃ βλαβερά καὶ κακοῦργος; ΛΑ. ναί. ΣΩ. καλὸν οὖν τι φήσεις σὺ εἶναι τὸ τοιοῦτον, ὃν

κακοῦργόν τε καὶ βλαβερόν; ΛΑ. οὐκ οὐν δίκαιόν γε, ὦ Σώκρατες. ΣΩ. οὐκ ἄρα τὴν γε τοιαύτην καρτερίαν ἀνδρείαν ὁμολογήσεις εἶναι, ἐπειδὴ περ οὐ καλὴ ἐστίν, ἡ δὲ ἀνδρεία καλὸν ἐστίν. ΛΑ. ἀληθῆ λέγεις. ΣΩ. ἡ φρόνιμος ἄρα καρτερία κατὰ τὸν σὸν λόγον ἀνδρεία ἂν εἴη. ΛΑ. ὅκειν.

**LA:** No, Socrates, that would not be right.

**S:** So you do not accept that endurance of this sort is courage, since it is not noble, and courage is noble.

**LA:** That is true.

**S:** So, based on your argument, wise endurance is courage.

**LA:** So it seems.

192e

**S:** Well, let us see. In what respect is it wise? Is it wise in all respects, significant and trivial? For instance, if someone endures in spending his money wisely, knowing that he will gain more from spending it, would you call this man courageous?

ΣΩ. ἴδωμεν δὴ, ἡ εἰς τί φρόνιμος; ἢ ἡ εἰς ἅπαντα καὶ τὰ μεγάλα καὶ τὰ σμικρά; οἷον εἴ τις καρτερεῖ ἀναλίσκων ἀργύριον φρονίμως, εἰδὼς ὅτι ἀναλώσας πλεον ἐκτίσεται, τοῦτον ἀνδρεῖον καλοῖς ἄν; ΛΑ. μὰ Δί' οὐκ ἔγωγε. ΣΩ. ἀλλ' οἷον εἴ τις ἰατρὸς ὢν, περιπλευμονίᾳ τοῦ ὑέος ἐχομένου ἢ ἄλλου τινὸς καὶ δεομένου πιεῖν ἢ φαγεῖν

**LA:** By Zeus, I would not.

193a

**S:** What if someone is a physician, and his son, or someone else with a lung infection, is begging for drink or food, and he is unyielding and endures in his refusal?

δοῦναι, μὴ κάμπτοιο ἀλλὰ καρτεροῖ; ΛΑ. οὐδ' ὁπωστιοῦν οὐδ' αὕτη. ΣΩ. ἀλλ' ἐν πολέμῳ καρτεροῦντα ἄνδρα καὶ ἐθέλοντα μάχεσθαι, φρονίμως λογιζόμενον, εἰδότα μὲν ὅτι βοηθήσουσιν ἄλλοι αὐτῷ, πρὸς ἐλάττους δὲ καὶ φαυλοτέρους μαχεῖται ἢ μεθ' ὧν αὐτός ἐστιν, ἔτι δὲ χωρία ἔχει

κρείττω, τοῦτον τὸν μετὰ τῆς τοιαύτης φρονήσεως καὶ παρασκευῆς καρτεροῦντα ἀνδρείότερον ἂν φαίης ἢ τὸν ἐν τῷ ἐναντίῳ στρατοπέδῳ ἐθέλοντα ὑπομένειν τε καὶ καρτερεῖν;

**LA:** No, that is not courage either, not at all.

**S:** And in war, what about a man who is prepared to fight, who calculates wisely, who knows that others will come to his aid, and that he is fighting against fewer troops, inferior to those on his side, whilst holding the better ground? Would you say that this man, who endures with this sort of wisdom, is more courageous than the man in the opposing army who is prepared to stand his ground and endure?

193b

**LA:** The man on the opposite side seems more courageous to me, Socrates.

ΛΑ. τὸν ἐν τῷ ἐναντίῳ, ἔμοιγε δοκεῖ, ὦ Σώκρατες. ΣΩ. ἀλλὰ μὴν ἀφρονεστέρα γε ἢ τούτου ἢ ἢ τοῦ ἐτέρου καρτερία. ΛΑ. ἀληθῆ λέγεις. ΣΩ. καὶ τὸν μετ' ἐπιστήμης ἄρα ἵπικῆς καρτεροῦντα ἐν ἵππομαχίᾳ ἦττον φήσεις ἀνδρεῖον εἶναι ἢ τὸν ἄνευ ἐπιστήμης. ΛΑ. ἔμοιγε δοκεῖ. ΣΩ. καὶ τὸν μετὰ σφενδονητικῆς ἢ τοξικῆς ἢ ἄλλης τινὸς τέχνης καρτεροῦντα.

**S:** And yet this man's endurance is more foolish than the other man's.

**LA:** That's true.

**S:** So you will also say that a man with knowledge of horsemanship, who endures in a cavalry battle, is less courageous than someone who does so without that knowledge.

**LA:** I think so.

**S:** And the one who endures, with knowledge of slinging or archery or any other skill, is less courageous.

193c

**LA:** Certainly.

ΛΑ. πάνυ γε. ΣΩ. καὶ ὅσοι ἂν ἐθέλωσιν εἰς φρέαρ καταβαίνοντες καὶ κολυμβῶντες καρτερεῖν ἐν τούτῳ τῷ ἔργῳ, μὴ ὄντες δεινοί, ἢ ἐν τινὶ ἄλλῳ τοιούτῳ, ἀνδρειότερους φήσεις τῶν ταῦτα δεινῶν. ΛΑ. τί γὰρ ἂν τις ἄλλο φαίη, ὦ Σώκρατες; ΣΩ. οὐδέν, εἴπερ οἰοίτο γε οὕτως. ΛΑ. ἀλλὰ μὴν οἶμαι γε. ΣΩ. καὶ μὴν που ἀφρονεστέρωσ γε, ὦ Λάχης, οἱ τοιοῦτοι κινδυνεύουσιν τε καὶ καρτεροῦσιν ἢ οἱ μετὰ τέχνης αὐτὸ πράττοντες. ΛΑ. φαίνονται.

**S:** And those who are prepared to go down into a well and dive, and who demonstrate endurance in this, or in another task like this, without being trained, will you say that they are more courageous than those who are trained?

**LA:** Yes, Socrates, what else could anyone say?

**S:** Nothing, if he actually thinks so.

**LA:** Well then, I think so at any rate.

**S:** And yet, Laches, such people are running risks and demonstrating endurance in a more foolish manner than those who perform the action with knowledge of the skill.

**LA:** Apparently.

*193d*

**S:** In our earlier discussion, did not foolish boldness and endurance prove to be shameful and harmful?

ΣΩ. οὐκοῦν αἰσχρὰ ἢ ἄφρων τόλμα τε καὶ καρτέρησις ἐν τῷ πρόσθεν ἐφάνη ἡμῖν οὕσα καὶ βλαβερὰ; ΛΑ. πάνυ γε. ΣΩ. ἡ δέ γε ἀνδρεία ὡμολογεῖτο καλὸν τι εἶναι. ΛΑ. ὡμολογεῖτο γάρ. ΣΩ. νῦν δ' αὖ πάλιν φαμέν ἐκεῖνο τὸ αἰσχρόν, τὴν ἄφρονα καρτέρησιν, ἀνδρεῖαν εἶναι. ΛΑ. ἐοίκαμεν. ΣΩ. καλῶς οὖν σοι δοκοῦμεν λέγειν; ΛΑ. μὰ τὸν Δί', ὦ Σώκρατες, ἐμοὶ μὲν οὐ. ΣΩ. οὐκ ἄρα που κατὰ τὸν σὸν λόγον δωριστὶ ἡρμόσμεθα

**LA:** Yes, certainly.

**S:** And yet courage was agreed to be something noble.

**LA:** Yes, that was agreed.

**S:** But now, on the contrary, we are saying that this shameful behaviour, foolish endurance, is courage.

**LA:** So it seems.

**S:** Well, do you think we are talking sense?

**LA:** By Zeus, Socrates, I do not.

193e

**S:** So I presume, to use your phrase, Laches, you and I are not attuned to the Doric mode, for our deeds are not in concord with our words. In fact, if someone were listening to our discussion now, he might declare that in action we do, it seems, partake of courage, but in words I think he would say that we do not.

ἐγὼ τε καὶ σύ, ὦ Λάχης· τὰ γὰρ ἔργα οὐ συμφωνεῖ ἡμῖν τοῖς λόγοις. ἔργῳ μὲν γάρ, ὡς ἔοικε, φαίη ἂν τις ἡμᾶς ἀνδρείας μετέχειν, λόγῳ δ', ὡς ἐγῶμαι, οὐκ ἂν, εἰ νῦν ἡμῶν ἀκούσειε διαλεγομένων. ΛΑ. ἀληθέστατα λέγεις. ΣΩ. τί οὖν; δοκεῖ καλὸν εἶναι οὕτως ἡμᾶς διακεῖσθαι; ΛΑ. οὐδ' ὅπωςτιοῦν. ΣΩ. βούλει οὖν ᾧ λέγομεν πειθώμεθα τό γε τοσοῦτον; ΛΑ. τὸ ποῖον δὴ τοῦτο, καὶ τίνι τούτῳ; ΣΩ. τῷ λόγῳ ὃς καρτερεῖν κελεύει. εἰ οὖν βούλει, καὶ ἡμεῖς ἐπὶ τῇ ζητήσει ἐπιμείνωμέν τε καὶ καρτερήσωμεν, ἵνα καὶ μὴ ἡμῶν αὕτη ἡ ἀνδρεία καταγελάσῃ, ὅτι οὐκ ἀνδρείως αὐτὴν ζητοῦμεν, εἰ ἄρα πολλάκις αὕτη ἡ καρτέρησίς ἐστιν ἀνδρεία. ΛΑ. ἐγὼ μὲν ἔτοιμος, ὦ Σώκρατες, μὴ προαφίστασθαι. καίτοι ἀήθης γ' εἰμὶ τῶν τοιούτων λόγων· ἀλλὰ τίς με καὶ φιλονικία εἴληφεν πρὸς τὰ εἰρημένα, καὶ ὡς ἀληθῶς ἀγανακτῶ

**LA:** Very true.

**S:** What about this? Do you think this is a good predicament for us to be in?

**LA:** No, not at all.

**S:** Well, do you want to accept our statement to this extent?

**LA:** To what extent, and what statement do you mean?

**S:** The statement that calls for endurance. So if you are willing, we too should stand our ground and endure in this search so that courage itself does not laugh at us, because we are not seeking it courageously if it turns out that endurance itself is courage after all.

194b

**LA:** Socrates, I am prepared to persist even though I am unaccustomed to discussions of this sort. But in the light of what has been said, I am gripped by a thirst for victory, and I am truly annoyed that I find myself unable to express the concept I have. For although I seem to have a concept of what courage is, I do not know how it escaped me just now so that I cannot get my words together to state what it is.

εἰ οὕτωςι ἃ νοῶ μὴ οἷός τ' εἰμὶ εἰπεῖν. νοεῖν μὲν γὰρ ἔμοιγε δοκῶ περὶ ἀνδρείας ὅτι ἔστιν, οὐκ οἶδα δ' ὅπῃ με ἄρτι διέφυγεν, ὥστε μὴ συλλαβεῖν τῷ λόγῳ αὐτήν καὶ εἰπεῖν ὅτι ἔστιν. ΣΩ. οὐκοῦν, ὦ φίλε, τὸν ἀγαθὸν κυνηγέτην μεταθεῖν χρή καὶ μὴ ἀνιέναι. ΛΑ. παντάπασι μὲν οὖν. ΣΩ. βούλει οὖν καὶ Νικίαν τόνδε παρακαλῶμεν ἐπὶ τὸ κυνηγέσιον, εἴ τι ἡμῶν εὐπορώτερός ἐστιν;

**S:** Well, my friend, the good huntsman should pursue his quarry and not give up.

**LA:** Entirely so.

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**S:** So, let us also invite Nicias here to the hunt. Do you agree? He may be more resourceful than we are.

ΛΑ. βούλομαι· πῶς γὰρ οὐ; ΣΩ. ἴθι δὴ, ὦ Νικία, ἀνδράσι φίλοις χειμαζομένοις ἐν λόγῳ καὶ ἀποροῦσιν βοήθησον, εἴ τινα ἔχεις δύναμιν. τὰ μὲν γὰρ δὴ ἡμέτερα ὀρᾷς ὡς ἄπορα· σὺ δ' εἰπὼν ὅτι ἡγῇ ἀνδρείαν εἶναι, ἡμᾶς τε τῆς ἀπορίας ἔκλυσαι καὶ αὐτὸς ἃ νοεῖς τῷ λόγῳ βεβαίωσαι. ΝΙ. δοκεῖτε τοίνυν μοι πάλαι οὐ καλῶς, ὦ Σώκρατες, ὀρίζεσθαι τὴν ἀνδρείαν· ὃ γὰρ ἐγὼ σοῦ ἤδη καλῶς λέγοντος ἀκήκοα, τούτῳ οὐ χρῆσθε. ΣΩ. ποίῳ δὴ, ὦ Νικία;

**LA:** I agree. Why wouldn't I?

**S:** Come then, Nicias. If you have the power to do so, you should come to the aid of your friends, who are caught up in a storm of discourse and are perplexed. You surely see how perplexed we are, but if you say what you think courage is, you will free us from the perplexity and give certainty to your own concept by putting it into words.

194d

**NI:** Well, it has seemed to me, Socrates, for quite some time that you are not defining courage properly. For you are not referring to an excellent maxim, which I have heard you stating before.

**NI.** πολλάκις ἀκήκοά σου λέγοντος ὅτι ταῦτα ἀγαθὸς ἕκαστος ἡμῶν ἄπερ σοφός, ἃ δὲ ἀμαθής, ταῦτα δὲ κακός. **ΣΩ.** ἀληθὴ μέντοι νῆ Δία λέγεις, ὦ Νικία. **NI.** οὐκοῦν εἴπερ ὁ ἀνδρεῖος ἀγαθός, δῆλον ὅτι σοφός ἐστιν. **ΣΩ.** ἤκουσας, ὦ Λάχης; **ΛΑ.** ἔγωγε, καὶ οὐ σφόδρα γε μανθάνω ὃ λέγει. **ΣΩ.** ἀλλ' ἐγὼ δοκῶ μανθάνειν, καί μοι δοκεῖ ἀνὴρ σοφίαν τινὰ τὴν ἀνδρείαν λέγειν. **ΛΑ.** ποίαν, ὦ Σώκρατες, σοφίαν;

**S:** What maxim, Nicias?

**NI:** I have often heard you say that 'each of us is good wherein he is wise and bad wherein he is foolish'.

**S:** Well, by Zeus, Nicias. That is true.

**NI:** In that case, if the brave man is indeed good, it is obvious that he is wise.

**S:** Did you hear that, Laches?

**LA:** I did, but I do not really understand what he is saying.

**S:** Well, I think I understand, and the man seems to me to be saying that courage is a kind of wisdom.

**LA:** What kind of wisdom, Socrates?

**S:** Why not put this question to the man himself?

**LA:** I am.

194e

**S:** Come on then, Nicias, tell him what sort of wisdom courage would be, according to your account. For I presume it is not the wisdom of flute-playing.

ΣΩ. οὐκοῦν τόνδε τοῦτο ἐρωτᾷς; ΛΑ. ἔγωγε. ΣΩ. ἴθι δὴ, αὐτῷ εἰπέ, ὦ Νικία, ποία σοφία ἀνδρεία ἂν εἴη κατὰ τὸν σὸν λόγον. οὐ γάρ που ἡ γε αὐλητική. ΝΙ. οὐδαμῶς. ΣΩ. οὐδὲ μὴν ἡ κιθαριστική. ΝΙ. οὐ δῆτα. ΣΩ. ἀλλὰ τίς δὴ αὕτη ἢ τίνος ἐπιστήμη; ΛΑ. πάνυ μὲν οὖν ὀρθῶς αὐτὸν ἐρωτᾷς, ὦ Σώκρατες, καὶ εἰπέτω γε τίνα φησὶν αὐτὴν εἶναι. ΝΙ. ταύτην ἔγωγε, ὦ Λάχης, τὴν τῶν δεινῶν καὶ θαρραλέων

**NI:** Not at all.

**S:** Nor indeed that of harp-playing.

**NI:** Of course not.

**S:** But what is it then? Knowledge of what?

**LA:** That certainly is the right way to question him, Socrates. He should say what he says it is.

195a

**NI:** I say, Laches, that it is the knowledge of what is to be feared and what is to be ventured, in war or in any other situation.

ἐπιστήμην καὶ ἐν πολέμῳ καὶ ἐν τοῖς ἄλλοις ἅπασιν. ΛΑ. ὥς ἄτοπα λέγει, ὦ Σώκρατες. ΣΩ. πρὸς τί τοῦτ' εἶπες βλέψας, ὦ Λάχης; ΛΑ. πρὸς ὅτι; χωρὶς δὴπου σοφία ἐστὶν ἀνδρείας. ΣΩ. οὐκ οὖν φησί γε Νικίας. ΛΑ. οὐ μέντοι μὰ Δία· ταῦτά τοι καὶ ληρεῖ. ΣΩ. οὐκοῦν διδάσκωμεν αὐτὸν ἀλλὰ μὴ λιοιδορῶμεν. ΝΙ. οὐκ, ἀλλὰ μοι δοκεῖ, ὦ Σώκρατες, Λάχης ἐπιθυμεῖν καμὲ φανῆναι μηδὲν λέγοντα, ὅτι καὶ αὐτὸς ἄρτι τοιοῦτός

**LA:** How strangely he speaks, Socrates.

**S:** What have you in mind when you say this, Laches?

**LA:** What? Wisdom is surely distinct from courage.

**S:** Yet Nicias says otherwise.

**LA:** Indeed he does, and talks nonsense in the process.

**S:** Then let us instruct him rather than abusing him.

**NI:** Well, Socrates, I think Laches wishes to make out that I too am talking nonsense because he was shown up for doing that sort of thing himself a moment ago.

195b

**LA:** Yes, indeed, Nicias, and I shall attempt to prove this at any rate, for you are talking nonsense. So, for instance, in the case of diseases, aren't the physicians the ones who know what is to be feared? Or do you think the courageous people know? Or do you call the physicians courageous?

τις ἐφάνη. ΛΑ. πάνυ μὲν οὖν, ὦ Νικία, καὶ πειράσομαί γε ἀποφῆναι· οὐδὲν γὰρ λέγεις. ἐπεὶ αὐτίκα ἐν ταῖς νόσοις οὐχ οἱ ἱατροὶ τὰ δεινὰ ἐπίστανται; ἢ οἱ ἀνδρεῖοι δοκοῦσί σοι ἐπίστασθαι; ἢ τοὺς ἱατροὺς σὺ ἀνδρείους καλεῖς; ΝΙ. οὐδ' ὁπωστιοῦν. ΛΑ. οὐδέ γε τοὺς γεωργοὺς οἶμαι. καίτοι τά γε ἐν τῇ γεωργίᾳ δεινὰ οὗτοι δήπου ἐπίστανται, καὶ οἱ ἄλλοι δημιουργοὶ ἅπαντες τὰ ἐν ταῖς αὐτῶν τέχναις δεινὰ τε καὶ

**NI:** No, not at all.

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**LA:** Nor the farmers either, I suppose, even though they surely know what is to be feared with regard to the cultivation of the earth. And all the other practitioners know what is to be feared and what is to be ventured in relation to their own areas of expertise. But that does not mean they are any more courageous.

θαρραλέα ἴσασιν· ἀλλ' οὐδέν τι μᾶλλον οὗτοι ἀνδρεῖοί εἰσιν. ΣΩ. τί δοκεῖ Λάχης λέγειν, ὦ Νικία; ἔοικεν μέντοι λέγειν τι. ΝΙ. καὶ γὰρ λέγει γέ τι, οὐ μέντοι ἀληθές γε. ΣΩ. πῶς δῆ; ΝΙ. ὅτι οἶεται τοὺς ἱατροὺς πλέον τι εἰδέναι περὶ τοὺς κάμνοντας ἢ τὸ ὑγιεινὸν εἰπεῖν οἷόν τε καὶ νοσῶδες. οἱ δὲ δήπου τοσοῦτον μόνον ἴσασιν· εἰ δὲ δεινὸν τῷ τοῦτό ἐστιν τὸ ὑγιαίνειν μᾶλλον ἢ τὸ κάμνειν, ἡγῇ σὺ τουτί, ὦ Λάχης, τοὺς

ἰατροὺς ἐπίστασθαι; ἢ οὐ πολλοῖς οἶει ἐκ τῆς νόσου ἄμεινον εἶναι μὴ ἀναστῆναι ἢ ἀναστῆναι; τοῦτο γὰρ εἶπέ·

**S:** What do you think Laches is saying, Nicias? He does seem to have a point.

**NI:** He has a point alright, but it is not true.

**S:** How so?

**NI:** Because he thinks physicians know something more about sick people than how to pronounce them healthy or ill. Yet this, surely, is the full extent of their knowledge. But, Laches, do you believe the physicians know if being healthy is to be feared by someone, more so than being ill? Or don't you think that it is better in many cases not to recover from an illness? Yes, tell me this. Do you maintain that it is better, in every case, to be alive? In many cases is it not preferable to be dead?

195d

**LA:** I think so.

σὺν πᾶσι φης ἄμεινον εἶναι ζῆν καὶ οὐ πολλοῖς κρεῖττον τεθνάναι; ΛΑ. οἶμαι ἔγωγε τοῦτό γε. ΝΙ. οἷς οὖν τεθνάναι λυσιτελεῖ, ταῦτά οἶει δεινὰ εἶναι καὶ οἷς ζῆν; ΛΑ. οὐκ ἔγωγε. ΝΙ. ἀλλὰ τοῦτο δὴ σὺ δίδως τοῖς ἰατροῖς γινώσκειν ἢ ἄλλῳ τινὶ δημιουργῷ πλὴν τῷ τῶν δεινῶν καὶ μὴ δεινῶν ἐπιστήμονι, ὃν ἐγὼ ἀνδρεῖον καλῶ; ΣΩ. κατανοεῖς, ὦ Λάχης, ὅτι λέγει;

**NI:** And do you think the same things are to be feared by those who are better off dead as by those who are better off alive?

**LA:** I do not.

**NI:** Well, do you attribute this knowledge to the physicians or to any other practitioner, apart from the man who knows what is to be feared and what is not – the man I call courageous?

**S:** Do you understand what he is saying, Laches?

195e

**LA:** I do. He is saying the soothsayers are the brave ones, for who else would know who is better off alive rather than dead? And what about yourself, Nicias? Do you admit to being a soothsayer, or are you neither a soothsayer nor courageous either?

ΛΑ. ἔγωγε, ὅτι γε τοὺς μάντις καλεῖ τοὺς ἀνδρείους· τίς γὰρ δὴ ἄλλος εἴσεται ὅτῳ ἄμεινον ζῆν ἢ τεθνάναι; καίτοι σύ, ὦ Νικία, πότερον ὁμολογεῖς μάντις εἶναι ἢ οὔτε μάντις οὔτε ἀνδρεῖος; ΝΙ. τί δέ; μάντει αὖ οἷε προσήκει τὰ δεινὰ γινώσκειν καὶ τὰ θαρραλέα; ΛΑ. ἔγωγε· τίνι γὰρ ἄλλῳ; ΝΙ. ὦι ἐγὼ λέγω πολὺ μᾶλλον, ὦ βέλτιστε· ἐπεὶ μάντιν γε τὰ σημεῖα μόνον δεῖ γινώσκειν τῶν ἐσομένων, εἴτε τῷ θάνατος εἴτε νόσος εἴτε ἀποβολὴ χρημάτων ἔσται,

**NI:** What is this? Do you yourself think that it is the role of the soothsayer to know what is to be feared and ventured?

**LA:** I do, otherwise whose role could it be?

**NI:** It is much more the role of the people I am speaking of, best of men, since the soothsayer need only recognise the signs of what will happen, whether someone will die or be ill or lose his property, whether he will be victorious or suffer defeat in war, or in any other contest. But it is no more a role for the soothsayer than for anyone else at all to decide which of these is best for someone to suffer or not suffer.

196a

**LA:** Well, Socrates, I do not understand from this what he wants to say, for he is explaining that he does not refer to the soothsayer or the physician, or anyone else, as a man of courage unless he is saying that it is some god. In fact, as I see it, Nicias is not willing to admit honestly that he is talking nonsense. Instead, he twists this way and that in an effort to conceal his own perplexity. Yet you and I could have performed similar twists a moment ago if we had wanted to avoid seeming to contradict ourselves. Well, if our arguments were being presented in a court of law, there might be some reason to do this, but

now, at a gathering of this sort, why would someone adorn himself vainly with empty words?

εἴτε νίκη εἴτε ἥττα ἢ πολέμου ἢ καὶ ἄλλης τινὸς ἀγωνίας· ὅτι δέ τω ἄμεινον τούτων ἢ παθεῖν ἢ μὴ παθεῖν, τί μᾶλλον μάντει προσήκει κρῖναι ἢ ἄλλω ὁτῶοῦν; ΛΑ. ἀλλ' ἐγὼ τούτου οὐ μανθάνω, ὦ Σώκρατες, ὅτι βούλεται λέγειν· οὔτε γὰρ μάντιν οὔτε ἰατρὸν οὔτε ἄλλον οὐδένα δηλοῖ ὄντινα λέγει τὸν ἀνδρεῖον, εἰ μὴ εἰ θεόν τινα λέγει αὐτὸν εἶναι. ἐμοὶ μὲν οὖν φαίνεται Νικίας οὐκ ἐθέλειν γενναίως ὁμολογεῖν ὅτι οὐδὲν λέγει, ἀλλὰ στρέφεται ἄνω καὶ κάτω ἐπικρυπτόμενος τὴν αὐτοῦ ἀπορίαν· καίτοι κἂν ἡμεῖς οἰοί τε ἡμεῖν ἄρτι ἐγὼ τε καὶ σὺ τοιαῦτα στρέφεσθαι, εἰ ἐβουλόμεθα μὴ δοκεῖν ἐναντία ἡμῖν αὐτοῖς λέγειν. εἰ μὲν οὖν ἐν δικαστηρίῳ ἡμῖν οἱ λόγοι ἦσαν, εἶχεν ἄν τινα λόγον ταῦτα ποιεῖν· νῦν δὲ τί ἄν τις ἐν συνουσίᾳ τοιᾷδε μάτην κενοῖς λόγοις αὐτὸς αὐτὸν κοσμοῖ;

196c

**S:** There is no reason to do so, Laches, but let us see. Perhaps Nicias thinks he has a point and is not saying all this just for the sake of talking. So let us find out from him, with greater clarity, what exactly he has in mind, and if it turns out that he has a point we shall go along with it, and if not we shall teach him.

ΣΩ. οὐδὲν οὐδ' ἐμοὶ δοκεῖ, ὦ Λάχης· ἀλλ' ὁρῶμεν μὴ Νικίας οἶεταί τι λέγειν καὶ οὐ λόγου ἔνεκα ταῦτα λέγει. αὐτοῦ οὖν σαφέστερον πυθώμεθα τί ποτε νοεῖ καὶ ἐάν τι φαίνεται λέγων, συγχωρησόμεθα, εἰ δὲ μὴ, διδάξομεν. ΛΑ. σὺ τοίνυν, ὦ Σώκρατες, εἰ βούλει πυθάνεσθαι, πυθάνου· ἐγὼ δ' ἴσως ἱκανῶς πέπυσμαι. ΣΩ. ἀλλ' οὐδέν με κωλύει κοινὴ γὰρ ἔσται ἡ πύστις ὑπὲρ ἐμοῦ τε καὶ σοῦ. ΛΑ. πάνυ μὲν οὖν. ΣΩ. λέγε δή μοι, ὦ Νικία—μᾶλλον δ' ἡμῖν κοινούμεθα

**LA:** Well then, Socrates, if you want to find out, go ahead and find out. Perhaps I have found out enough.

**S:** That will not stop me. Indeed, the enquiry will be on my behalf and yours.

**LA:** Very well then.

**S:** So tell me, Nicias, or rather tell us both, since Laches and myself are sharing the conversation: are you saying that courage is knowledge of what is to be feared and what is to be ventured?

**NI:** I am.

**S:** And this knowledge does not belong to everyone, since neither the physician nor the soothsayer will know this, nor will they be courageous unless they acquire this particular knowledge. Isn't this what you were saying?

**NI:** It was indeed.

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**S:** So in fact, as the saying goes, 'not every sow would know this', nor would she be courageous.

γὰρ ἐγὼ τε καὶ Λάχης τὸν λόγον—τὴν ἀνδρείαν ἐπιστήμην φῆς δεινῶν τε καὶ θαρραλέων εἶναι; NI. ἔγωγε. ΣΩ. τοῦτο δὲ οὐ παντὸς δὴ εἶναι ἀνδρὸς γινῶναι, ὅποτε γε μήτε ἰατρὸς μήτε μάντις αὐτὸ γινώσεται μηδὲ ἀνδρείος ἔσται, ἐὰν μὴ αὐτὴν ταύτην τὴν ἐπιστήμην προσλάβῃ· οὐχ οὕτως ἔλεγες; NI. οὕτω μὲν οὔν. ΣΩ. κατὰ τὴν παροιμίαν ἄρα τῷ ὄντι οὐκ ἂν πᾶσα ὅς γινοίη οὐδ' ἂν ἀνδρεία γένοιτο. NI. οὐ μοι δοκεῖ.

**NI:** I think not.

**S:** Obviously, Nicias, you do not believe that even the Crommyonian sow was courageous. And I am not saying this in jest. No, I think it is necessary that someone who maintains this should not accept that any wild beast is courageous, or agree that any wild animal is wise in this way, and thus maintain that a lion, a leopard or some boar knows what very few humans know, because it's so hard to know. But someone who proposes that courage is what you are proposing it is must maintain that a lion, a stag, a bull or a monkey are, by nature, equally courageous.

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**LA:** By the gods, Socrates, you are putting that well. And you should answer this truthfully for us, Nicias. Are you saying that these wild animals, who everyone agrees are courageous, are wiser than we are, or would you dare to go against everyone and not even call them courageous?

ΣΩ. δῆλον δὴ, ὦ Νικία, ὅτι οὐδὲ τὴν Κρομμυωνίαν ὕν πιστεύεις σύ γε ἀνδρείαν γεγονέναι. τοῦτο δὲ λέγω οὐ παίζων, ἀλλ' ἀναγκαῖον οἶμαι τῷ ταῦτα λέγοντι μηδενὸς θηρίου ἀποδέχεσθαι ἀνδρείαν, ἢ συγχωρεῖν θηρίον τι οὕτω σοφὸν εἶναι, ὥστε ἂ ὀλίγοι ἀνθρώπων ἴσασι διὰ τὸ χαλεπὰ εἶναι γινῶναι, ταῦτα λέοντα ἢ πάρδαλιν ἢ τινα κάπρον φάναι εἶδέναι· ἀλλ' ἀνάγκη ὁμοίως λέοντα καὶ ἔλαφον καὶ ταῦρον καὶ πίθηκον πρὸς ἀνδρείαν φάναι πεφυκέναι τὸν τιθέμενον ἀνδρείαν τοῦθ' ὅπερ σὺ τίθεις. ΛΑ. νῆ τοὺς θεοὺς, καὶ εὖ γε λέγεις, ὦ Σώκρατες. καὶ ἡμῖν ὡς ἀληθῶς τοῦτο ἀπόκριναι, ὦ Νικία, πότερον σοφώτερα φῆς ἡμῶν ταῦτα εἶναι τὰ θηρία, ἂ πάντες ὁμολογοῦμεν ἀνδρεῖα εἶναι, ἢ πᾶσιν ἐναντιούμενος τολμᾷς μηδὲ ἀνδρεῖα αὐτὰ καλεῖν; ΝΙ. οὐ γάρ τι, ὦ Λάχης, ἔγωγε ἀνδρεῖα καλῶ οὔτε θηρία οὔτε ἄλλο οὐδὲν τὸ τὰ δεινὰ ὑπὸ ἀνοίας μὴ φοβούμενον, ἀλλ' ἄφοβον καὶ μῶρον· ἢ καὶ τὰ παιδιά πάντα οἷε με

**NI:** Laches, I do not call wild animals courageous, or anything else that does not fear what is to be feared because it lacks intelligence. Instead, I call them fearless or stupid. Do you think I even call all the children, who fear nothing because they lack intelligence, courageous? No, to my mind fearlessness and courage are not the same. I am of the opinion that courage and foresight belong to very few, while rashness, daring and fearlessness, devoid of foresight, belong to a vast number of men, women, children and wild beasts. So actions that you and most others call courageous, I call rash, but the wise actions I am referring to are courageous.

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**LA:** Do you see, Socrates, how nicely this fellow adorns himself with words? Or so he thinks. Yet he is trying to deprive those who are

universally agreed to be courageous of their due respect.

ἀνδρεῖα καλεῖν, ἃ δι' ἄνοιαν οὐδὲν δέδοικεν; ἀλλ' οἶμαι τὸ ἄφοβον καὶ τὸ ἀνδρεῖον οὐ ταυτόν ἐστιν. ἐγὼ δὲ ἀνδρείας μὲν καὶ προμηθείας πάνυ τισὶν ὀλίγοις οἶμαι μετεῖναι, θρασύτητος δὲ καὶ τόλμης καὶ τοῦ ἀφόβου μετὰ ἀπρομηθείας πάνυ πολλοῖς καὶ ἀνδρῶν καὶ γυναικῶν καὶ παίδων καὶ θηρίων. ταῦτ' οὖν ἃ σὺ καλεῖς ἀνδρεῖα καὶ οἱ πολλοί, ἐγὼ

**NI:** Laches, I am not referring to you, so take heart. Indeed, I declare that you are wise, and Lamachus<sup>6</sup> too, if you are actually courageous, and so are a host of other Athenians.

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**LA:** I could respond to that but I shall say nothing, so that you cannot accuse me of being, in truth, an abusive Aexonian.

θρασέα καλῶ, ἀνδρεῖα δὲ τὰ φρόνιμα περὶ ὧν λέγω. ΛΑ. θεάσαι, ὦ Σώκρατες, ὡς εὖ ὁδε ἑαυτὸν δὴ, ὡς οἶεται, κοσμεῖ τῷ λόγῳ· οὓς δὲ πάντες ὁμολογοῦσιν ἀνδρείους εἶναι, τούτους ἀποστερεῖν ἐπιχειρεῖ ταύτης τῆς τιμῆς. ΝΙ. οὐκ οὐκ σέ γε, ὦ Λάχης, ἀλλὰ θάρρει φημί γάρ σε εἶναι σοφόν, καὶ Λάμαχόν γε, εἴπερ ἐστὲ ἀνδρεῖοι, καὶ ἄλλους γε συχνούς Ἀθηναίων. ΛΑ. οὐδὲν ἐρῶ πρὸς ταῦτα, ἔχων εἰπεῖν, ἵνα μή με φῆς ὡς ἀληθῶς Αἰξωνέα εἶναι.

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**S:** Do not speak, Laches. In fact, you seem to be unaware that he has acquired this wisdom from our mutual friend, Damon, and Damon is a constant associate of Prodicus, who is reputed to be the very best of the sophists at making verbal distinctions of this kind.

ΣΩ. μηδέ γε εἴπης, ὦ Λάχης· καὶ γάρ μοι δοκεῖς οὐδὲ ἡσθῆσθαι ὅτι ταύτην τὴν σοφίαν παρὰ Δάμωνος τοῦ ἡμετέρου ἐταίρου παρείληφεν, ὃ δὲ Δάμων τῷ προδίκῳ πολλὰ πλησιάζει, ὃς δὴ δοκεῖ τῶν σοφιστῶν κάλλιστα τὰ τοιαῦτα ὀνόματα διαιρεῖν. ΛΑ. καὶ γὰρ πρέπει, ὦ Σώκρατες, σοφιστῇ τὰ τοιαῦτα μᾶλλον κομψεύεσθαι ἢ ἀνδρὶ ὃν ἡ πόλις ἀξιοῖ αὐτῆς προεστάναι.

**LA:** Yes, indeed, Socrates, it is more appropriate for a sophist to engage in such subtleties than a man whom the city chooses as her leader.

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**S:** Blessed man, it is surely appropriate that those who provide leadership in matters of the greatest importance should partake of wisdom to the greatest extent. Yet I think Nicias merits questioning as to his point of view when he uses this word courage.

ΣΩ. πρέπει μὲν που, ὦ μακάριε, τῶν μεγίστων προστατοῦντι μεγίστης φρονήσεως μετέχειν· δοκεῖ δέ μοι Νικίας ἄξιος εἶναι ἐπισκέψεως, ὅποι ποτὲ βλέπων τοῦνομα τοῦτο τίθησι τὴν ἀνδρείαν. ΛΑ. αὐτὸς τοίνυν σκόπει, ὦ Σώκρατες. ΣΩ. τοῦτο μέλλω ποιεῖν, ὦ ἄριστε· μὴ μέντοι οἷου με ἀφήσειν σε τῆς κοινωνίας τοῦ λόγου, ἀλλὰ πρόσεχε τὸν νοῦν καὶ συσκόπει τὰ λεγόμενα. ΛΑ. ταῦτα δὴ ἔστω, εἰ δοκεῖ χρῆναι. ΣΩ. ἀλλὰ δοκεῖ. σὺ δέ, Νικία, λέγε ἡμῖν πάλιν ἐξ

**LA:** Well, question him yourself, Socrates.

**S:** That is what I am about to do, best of men. However, you should not assume that I will release you from your shared role in the argument, so pay attention and consider whatever is said, along with me.

**LA:** So be it, if it seems necessary.

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**S:** So it does. And you, Nicias, should address us again from the beginning. You know, don't you, that at the beginning of the discussion we were considering courage on the basis that it was a part of excellence?

ἀρχῆς οἷσθ' ὅτι τὴν ἀνδρείαν κατ' ἀρχὰς τοῦ λόγου ἐσκοποῦμεν ὡς μέρος ἀρετῆς σκοποῦντες; ΝΙ. πάνυ γε. ΣΩ. οὐκοῦν καὶ σὺ τοῦτο ἀπεκρίνω ὡς μόριον, ὄντων δὴ καὶ ἄλλων μερῶν, ἃ σύμπαντα ἀρετὴ κέκληται; ΝΙ. πῶς γὰρ οὐ; ΣΩ. ἄρ' οὖν ἅπερ ἐγὼ καὶ σὺ ταῦτα λέγεις; ἐγὼ δὲ καλῶ πρὸς ἀνδρείαν σωφροσύνην καὶ δικαιοσύνην καὶ ἄλλ' ἅττα τοιαῦτα. οὐ καὶ σύ;

**NI:** Certainly.

**S:** Did you not also give this answer: that it is a part, and there are other parts too, and when taken all together they are called excellence?

**NI:** Of course.

**S:** Now, do you speak of these parts as I do? As well as courage, I call sound-mindedness, justice, and the like parts of excellence. Don't you?

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**NI:** Entirely so.

NI. πάνυ μὲν οὖν. ΣΩ. ἔχε δὴ. ταῦτα μὲν γὰρ ὁμολογοῦμεν, περὶ δὲ τῶν δεινῶν καὶ θαρραλέων σκεψώμεθα, ὅπως μὴ σὺ μὲν ἄλλ' ἄττα ἡγῇ, ἡμεῖς δὲ ἄλλα. ἃ μὲν οὖν ἡμεῖς ἡγούμεθα, φράσομέν σοι· σὺ δὲ ἂν μὴ ὁμολογῇς, διδάξεις. ἡγούμεθα δ' ἡμεῖς δεινὰ μὲν εἶναι ἃ καὶ δέος παρέχει, θαρραλέα δὲ ἃ μὴ δέος παρέχει—δέος δὲ παρέχει οὐ τὰ γεγονότα οὐδὲ τὰ παρόντα τῶν κακῶν, ἀλλὰ τὰ προσδοκώμενα· δέος γὰρ εἶναι προσδοκίαν μέλλοντος κακοῦ—ἢ οὐχ οὕτω καὶ συνδοκεῖ, ὧς Λάχης;

**S:** Stop there, since we agree on these, and let us consider what is to be feared and what is to be ventured, in case you are of one view while we are of another. So we shall tell you what we think, and if you do not agree, you should instruct us. According to us, things that cause fear are to be feared, while those that do not are to be ventured. But it is not past evils that cause fear, or the present ones either, but only those that are anticipated, for fear is the anticipation of impending evil. Don't you agree with me, Laches?

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**LA:** Very much so, Socrates.

ΛΑ. πάνυ γε σφόδρα, ὦ Σώκρατες. ΣΩ. τὰ μὲν ἡμέτερα τοίνυν, ὦ Νικία, ἀκούεις, ὅτι δεινὰ μὲν τὰ μέλλοντα κακὰ φαμεν εἶναι, θαρραλέα δὲ τὰ μὴ κακὰ ἢ ἀγαθὰ μέλλοντα· σὺ δὲ ταύτη ἢ ἄλλη περὶ τούτων λέγεις; ΝΙ. ταύτη ἔγωγε. ΣΩ. τούτων δέ γε τὴν ἐπιστήμην ἀνδρείαν προσαγορεύεις;

NI. κομιδῇ γε. ΣΩ. ἔτι δὴ τὸ τρίτον σκεψώμεθα εἰ συνδοκεῖ σοί τε καὶ ἡμῖν. NI. τὸ ποῖον δὴ τοῦτο;

**S:** Well, Nicias, you have heard our views that, according to us, the impending evils are to be feared, while impending goods, or things that are not evil, are to be ventured. Is this the way you describe them, or is there another way?

**NI:** This way.

**S:** And the knowledge of these you refer to as courage?

**NI:** Precisely.

**S:** We should still consider whether we are all in agreement on a third issue.

**NI:** What issue is that?

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**S:** I shall tell you. It seems to myself, and to this man, that in cases where there is knowledge of something, there is not one knowledge that knows how things happened in the past, another concerned with how they are happening at present, and another dealing with how what has not yet happened will happen, and may best happen. No, it is the same knowledge. For example, in the case of past, present and future health, no other knowledge, apart from medicine, as one, superintends what is happening, what has happened, and how what is going to happen will unfold. And the same also holds for farming, in the case of what is produced from the earth. And when it comes to warfare, the two of you will of course bear witness to the fact that generalship, on the whole, best foresees the future, and it does not believe that it should be subservient even to the soothsayer in relation to the future. No, generalship should rule, as it has better knowledge of how military affairs are unfolding and will unfold. And so the law decrees that the soothsayer has no authority over the general. No, the general has authority over the soothsayer. Is this what we shall say, Laches?

ΣΩ. ἐγὼ δὴ φράσω. δοκεῖ γὰρ δὴ ἐμοί τε καὶ τῷδε, περὶ ὧν ἐστὶν ἐπιστήμη, οὐκ ἄλλη μὲν εἶναι περὶ γεγονότος εἰδέναι ὅπῃ γέγονεν, ἄλλη δὲ περὶ γιγνομένων ὅπῃ γίγνεται, ἄλλη δὲ ὅπῃ ἂν κάλλιστα γένοιτο καὶ γενήσεται τὸ μήπω γεγονός, ἀλλ' ἡ αὐτή. οἷον περὶ τὸ ὑγιεινὸν εἰς ἅπαντας τοὺς χρόνους οὐκ ἄλλη τις ἢ ἱατρική, μία οὖσα, ἐφορᾷ καὶ γιγνόμενα καὶ γεγονότα καὶ γενησόμενα ὅπῃ

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**LA:** It is.

γενήσεται· καὶ περὶ τὰ ἐκ τῆς γῆς αὖ φυόμενα ἢ γεωργία ὡσαύτως ἔχει· ΣΩ. καὶ δήπου τὰ περὶ τὸν πόλεμον αὐτοὶ ἂν μαρτυρήσαιτε ὅτι ἡ στρατηγία κάλλιστα προμηθεῖται τὰ τε ἄλλα καὶ περὶ τὸ μέλλον ἔσεσθαι, οὐδὲ τῇ μαντικῇ οἴεται δεῖν ὑπηρετεῖν ἀλλὰ ἄρχειν, ὡς εἰδυῖα κάλλιον

**S:** What about this, Nicias? Do you agree with us, that in dealing with the same issues the same knowledge knows about the future, the present and the past?

**NI:** I do, yes. That is how it seems to me, Socrates.

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**S:** Now, best of men, do you not also say that courage is knowledge of what is to be feared and ventured? Is this so?

τὰ περὶ τὸν πόλεμον καὶ γιγνόμενα καὶ γενησόμενα καὶ ὁ νόμος οὕτω τάττει, μὴ τὸν μάντιν τοῦ στρατηγοῦ ἄρχειν, ἀλλὰ τὸν στρατηγὸν τοῦ μάντεως. φήσομεν ταῦτα, ὦ Λάχης; ΛΑ. φήσομεν. ΣΩ. τί δέ; σὺ ἡμῖν, ὦ Νικία, σύμφης περὶ τῶν αὐτῶν τὴν αὐτὴν ἐπιστήμην καὶ ἐσομένων καὶ γιγνομένων καὶ γεγονότων ἐπαίειν; ΝΙ. ἔγωγε· δοκεῖ γάρ μοι οὕτως, ὦ Σώκρατες. ΣΩ. οὐκοῦν, ὦ ἄριστε, καὶ ἡ ἀνδρεία τῶν δεινῶν ἐπιστήμη

**NI:** Yes.

**S:** And it was accepted that what is to be feared and what is to be ventured are future goods and future evils?

**NI:** Entirely so.

**S:** And the same knowledge is concerned with the same matters in the future, or at any other stage?

**NI:** This is the case.

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**S:** In that case, courage is not only knowledge of what is to be feared and what is to be ventured. No, just like the other kinds of knowledge, it has knowledge not only of impending goods and evils, but also of those that are present, or past, or at any other stage.

ἐστὶν καὶ θαρραλέων, ὥς φήσ· ἧ γάρ; NI. ναί. ΣΩ. τὰ δὲ δεινὰ ὠμολόγηται καὶ τὰ θαρραλέα τὰ μὲν μέλλοντα ἀγαθὰ, τὰ δὲ μέλλοντα κακὰ εἶναι. NI. πάνυ γε. ΣΩ. ἡ δὲ γ' αὐτὴ ἐπιστήμη τῶν αὐτῶν καὶ μελλόντων καὶ πάντως ἐχόντων εἶναι. NI. ἔστι ταῦτα. ΣΩ. οὐ μόνον ἄρα τῶν δεινῶν καὶ θαρραλέων ἡ ἀνδρεία ἐπιστήμη ἐστίν· οὐ γὰρ μελλόντων μόνον περὶ τῶν ἀγαθῶν τε καὶ κακῶν ἐπαίει, ἀλλὰ καὶ γιγνομένων καὶ γεγονότων

**NI:** So it seems, anyway.

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**S:** So, Nicias, the answer you gave us constitutes part of courage, one third at best, even though we asked you what courage was as a whole. And indeed it now seems, based upon your argument, that courage is not just knowledge of what is to be feared and ventured, but according to your present argument, courage would more or less be knowledge of all good and evil in all cases. May we make this adjustment? What do you say, Nicias?

καὶ πάντως ἐχόντων, ὥσπερ αἱ ἄλλαι ἐπιστήμαι. NI. ἔοικέν γε. ΣΩ. μέρος ἄρα ἀνδρείας ἡμῖν, ὃ Νικία, ἀπεκρίνω σχεδόν τι τρίτον· καίτοι ἡμεῖς ἡρωτῶμεν ὅλην ἀνδρείαν ὅτι εἴη. καὶ νῦν δὴ, ὥς ἔοικεν, κατὰ τὸν σὸν λόγον οὐ μόνον δεινῶν τε καὶ θαρραλέων ἐπιστήμη ἡ ἀνδρεία ἐστίν, ἀλλὰ σχεδόν τι ἡ περὶ πάντων ἀγαθῶν τε καὶ κακῶν καὶ πάντως ἐχόντων, ὥς

**NI:** I think so, Socrates.

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**S:** Now, do you think, blessed man, someone like this would be lacking in any excellence, if he actually knew good in its entirety, and fully understood how it arises, will arise, and has arisen, and understood evil in like manner? And do you think this man would be deficient in sound-mindedness or justice or holiness when he alone is equipped to pay careful attention to what is to be feared, or not, in relation to gods or humans, and to ensure good outcomes by knowing how to deal with them aright?

νῦν αὖ ὁ σὸς λόγος, ἀνδρεία ἂν εἴη. οὕτως αὖ μετατίθεσθαι ἢ πῶς λέγεις, ὦ Νικία; ΝΙ. ἔμοιγε δοκεῖ, ὦ Σώκρατες. ΣΩ. δοκεῖ οὖν σοι, ὦ δαιμόνιε, ἀπολείπειν ἂν τι ὁ τοιοῦτος ἀρετῆς, εἴπερ εἰδείη τά τε ἀγαθὰ πάντα καὶ παντάπασιν ὡς γίγνεται καὶ γενήσεται καὶ γέγονε, καὶ τὰ κακὰ ὡσαύτως; καὶ τοῦτον οἶε ἂν σὺ ἐνδεᾶ εἶναι σωφροσύνης ἢ δικαιοσύνης τε καὶ δσιότητος, ὥ γε μόνῳ προσήκει καὶ περὶ θεοῦ καὶ περὶ ἀνθρώπων ἐξευλαβεῖσθαι τε τὰ δεινὰ καὶ τὰ

**NI:** I think you have a point, Socrates.

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**S:** In that case, Nicias, what you are now describing would not be a part of excellence, but excellence in its entirety.

μή, καὶ τὰγαθὰ πορίζεσθαι, ἐπισταμένῳ ὀρθῶς προσομιλεῖν; ΝΙ. λέγειν τι ὦ Σώκρατές μοι δοκεῖς. ΣΩ. οὐκ ἄρα, ὦ Νικία, μόνιον ἀρετῆς ἂν εἴη τὸ νῦν σοι λεγόμενον, ἀλλὰ σύμπασα ἀρετή. ΝΙ. ἔοικεν. ΣΩ. καὶ μὴν ἔφαμέν γε τὴν ἀνδρείαν μόνιον εἶναι ἐν τῶν τῆς ἀρετῆς. ΝΙ. ἔφαμεν γάρ. ΣΩ. τὸ δέ γε νῦν λεγόμενον οὐ φαίνεται. ΝΙ. οὐκ ἔοικεν. ΣΩ. οὐκ ἄρα ἠρῆκαμεν, ὦ Νικία, ἀνδρεία ὅτι ἔστιν. ΝΙ. οὐ φαινόμεθα. ΛΑ. καὶ μὴν ἔγωγε, ὦ φίλε Νικία, ὥμην σε εὐρήσειν,

**NI:** So it seems.

**S:** Yet we said that courage is one of the parts of excellence.

**NI:** Yes, we said that.

**S:** But what is now being described does not appear to be a part.

**NI:** It seems not.

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**S:** In that case, Nicias, we have not discovered what courage is.

ἐπειδὴ ἐμοῦ κατεφρόνησας Σωκράτει ἀποκριναμένου· πάνυ δὴ μεγάλην ἐλπίδα εἶχον, ὡς τῇ παρὰ τοῦ Δάμωνος σοφίᾳ αὐτὴν ἀνευρήσεις. NI. εὖ γε, ὦ Λάχης, ὅτι οὐδὲν οἶμι σὺ ἔτι πρᾶγμα εἶναι ὅτι αὐτὸς ἄρτι ἐφάνης ἀνδρείας περὶ οὐδὲν εἰδώς, ἀλλ' εἰ καὶ ἐγὼ ἕτερος τοιοῦτος ἀναφανήσομαι, πρὸς τοῦτο βλέπεις, καὶ οὐδὲν ἔτι διοίσει, ὡς ἔοικε, σοὶ μετ' ἐμοῦ μηδὲν εἰδέναι ὧν προσήκει ἐπιστήμην ἔχειν ἀνδρὶ οἰομένῳ τι εἶναι. σὺ μὲν οὖν μοι δοκεῖς ὡς ἀληθῶς ἀνθρώπειον πρᾶγμα ἐργάζεσθαι οὐδὲ πρὸς σαυτὸν βλέπειν ἀλλὰ πρὸς τοὺς ἄλλους· ἐγὼ δ' οἶμαι ἐμοὶ περὶ ὧν ἐλέγομεν νῦν τε ἐπιεικῶς εἰρῆσθαι, καὶ εἴ τι αὐτῶν μὴ ἱκανῶς εἴρηται, ὕστερον ἐπανορθώσεσθαι καὶ μετὰ Δάμωνος—οὗ σύ που οἶμι καταγελᾶν, καὶ ταῦτα οὐδ' ἰδὼν πώποτε τὸν Δάμωνα—καὶ μετ' ἄλλων· καὶ ἐπειδὴ βεβαιώσωμαι αὐτά, διδάξω καὶ σέ, καὶ οὐ φθονήσω· δοκεῖς

**NI:** Apparently we have not.

**LA:** But Nicias, my friend, I assumed you were going to make the discovery when you were so contemptuous of my responses to Socrates. Yes, I really had great hopes that you would discover it, using this wisdom you acquired from Damon.

**NI:** That is nice, Laches. You still do not think it is a problem that you yourself, earlier, proved to know nothing about courage. No, as long as I am shown up as someone else like that, that is what you focus on, and it seems to make no difference to you that you know as little as I do about issues on which a man of any reputation should be knowledgeable. Now, you seem to me to be acting in a truly human fashion by focussing not upon yourself, but on other people. As for myself, I think the issues we have discussed have now been adequately dealt with, and if any of them have not been covered in a satisfactory manner I shall correct them in due course with the help of Damon, whom you somehow think you can ridicule without ever having set

eyes on Damon himself, and with the help of others too. And once I am certain about them, I shall also teach you. I shall not begrudge you that, for you seem to me to be very much in need of instruction.

200c

**LA:** Well, Nicias, you are wise, but nevertheless I am advising Lysimachus here, and Melesias, to bid yourself and myself farewell when it comes to the education of the young men. But as I said at the outset, they should hold on to this man, Socrates, and if my own sons had been at the right age I would have done the very same thing.

γάρ μοι καὶ μάλα σφόδρα δεῖσθαι μαθεῖν. ΛΑ. σοφὸς γάρ τοι σὺ εἶ, ὦ Νικία. ἀλλ' ὅμως ἐγὼ Λυσιμάχῳ τῷδε καὶ Μελησίᾳ συμβουλεύω σὲ μὲν καὶ ἐμὲ περὶ τῆς παιδείας τῶν νεανίσκων χαίρειν ἔαν, Σωκράτη δὲ τουτονί, ὅπερ ἐξ ἀρχῆς ἔλεγον, μὴ ἀφιέναι· εἰ δὲ καὶ ἐμοὶ ἐν ἡλικίᾳ ἦσαν οἱ παῖδες, ταῦτ' ἂν ταῦτ' ἐποίουν. ΝΙ. ταῦτα μὲν κἀγὼ συγχωρῶ· ἐάνπερ ἐθέλῃ Σωκράτης τῶν μειρακίων ἐπιμελεῖσθαι, μηδὲνα ἄλλον ζητεῖν. ἐπεὶ κἂν

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**NI:** There I agree with you. If Socrates is prepared to look after the young men, do not search for anyone else. Indeed, I would gladly entrust Niceratus to this man if he were willing. But the fact is, every time I raise the matter with him he recommends someone else, and is unwilling to do it himself. But, Lysimachus, see if Socrates will be more responsive to you.

ἐγὼ τὸν Νικήρατον τούτῳ ἥδιστα ἐπιτρέποιμι, εἰ ἐθέλοι οὗτος· ἀλλὰ γὰρ ἄλλους μοι ἐκάστοτε συνίστησιν, ὅταν τι αὐτῷ περὶ τούτου μνησθῶ, αὐτὸς δὲ οὐκ ἐθέλει. ἀλλ' ὅρα, ὦ Λυσίμαχε, εἴ τι σοῦ ἂν μᾶλλον ὑπακούοι Σωκράτης. ΛΥ. δίκαιόν γέ τοι, ὦ Νικία, ἐπεὶ καὶ ἐγὼ τούτῳ πολλὰ ἂν ἐθελήσαιμι ποιεῖν, ἃ οὐκ ἂν ἄλλοις πάνυ πολλοῖς ἐθέλοιμι. πῶς οὖν φῆς, ὦ Σώκρατες; ὑπακούσῃ τι καὶ συμπροθυμήσῃ ὡς βελτίστοις γενέσθαι τοῖς μειρακίοις;

**LY:** It is only right that he should, Nicias, since I would be willing to do a great deal for him that I would be reluctant to do for very many

others. So what do you say, Socrates? Will you respond and share in our eagerness that the boys become as good as they possibly can?

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**S:** The fact is, Lysimachus, that it would be a terrible thing to be reluctant to share in the eagerness that anyone become as good as possible. Now, if in the course of our earlier discussions I had turned out to be knowledgeable and these two gentlemen had not, it would have been right to invite me, in particular, to take on this role, but as it is we have all ended up in a similar state of perplexity. So why would anyone prefer one of us over the other? So, in my opinion, none of us should be chosen. But since that is how matters stand, think about the piece of advice I am about to give you. For I declare, gentlemen – and my statement is not to be made public – that all of us ought to search together for the best teacher we can find, for ourselves first and foremost, for we really need one, and then for the young men too, sparing neither money nor anything else. But I do not recommend that we remain in our present condition. And if anyone should laugh at us because we still see merit in frequenting teachers at our time of life, I think we should quote Homer who says that ‘modesty is not a good companion for a man in need’. And so we, paying no heed to what anyone may say, should jointly undertake the care of our own selves and of the young men.

ΣΩ. καὶ γὰρ ἂν δεινὸν εἴη, ὦ Λυσίμαχε, τοῦτό γε, μὴ ἐθέλειν τῷ συμπροθυμεῖσθαι ὡς βελτίστῳ γενέσθαι. εἰ μὲν οὖν ἐν τοῖς διαλόγοις τοῖς ἄρτι ἐγὼ μὲν ἐφάνην εἰδώς, τῷδε δὲ μὴ εἰδότε, δίκαιον ἂν ἦν ἐμὲ μάλιστα ἐπὶ τοῦτο τὸ ἔργον παρακαλεῖν, νῦν δ’ ὁμοίως γὰρ πάντες ἐν ἀπορίᾳ ἐγενόμεθα· τί οὖν ἂν τις ἡμῶν τίνα προαιροῖτο; ΣΩ. ἐμοὶ μὲν οὖν δὴ αὐτῷ δοκεῖ οὐδένα· ἀλλ’ ἐπειδὴ ταῦτα οὕτως ἔχει, σκέψασθε ἂν τι δόξω συμβουλεύειν ὑμῖν. ἐγὼ γάρ φημι χρῆναι, ὦ ἄνδρες —οὐδεὶς γὰρ ἔκφορος λόγος—κοινῇ πάντας ἡμᾶς ζητεῖν μάλιστα μὲν ἡμῖν αὐτοῖς διδάσκαλον ὡς ἄριστον—δεόμεθα γάρ—ἔπειτα καὶ τοῖς μειρακίοις, μήτε χρημάτων φειδομένους μήτε ἄλλου μηδενός· ἔαν δὲ

ἡμᾶς αὐτοὺς ἔχειν ὥς νῦν ἔχομεν οὐ συμβουλευώ. εἰ δέ τις ἡμῶν καταγελάσεται, ὅτι

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**LY:** Socrates, I am delighted at what you are saying, and insofar as I am the oldest man here, I am also the one who is most eager to learn, along with the young ones. So I want you to do something for me. Come to my home tomorrow at daybreak, without fail, so that we may deliberate on these very issues. But let us break up our gathering for the moment.

τηλικοῖδε ὄντες εἰς διδασκάλων ἀξιοῦμεν φοιτᾶν, τὸν Ὅμηρον δοκεῖ μοι χρῆναι προβάλλεσθαι, ὃς ἔφη οὐκ ἀγαθὴν εἶναι αἰδῶ κεχρημένῳ ἀνδρὶ παρεῖναι. καὶ ἡμεῖς οὖν ἐάσαντες χαίρειν εἴ τίς τι ἐρεῖ, κοινῇ ἡμῶν αὐτῶν καὶ τῶν μειρακίων ἐπιμέλειαν ποιησώμεθα. ΛΥ. ἐμοὶ μὲν ἀρέσκει, ὦ Σώκρατες, ἃ λέγεις· καὶ ἐθέλω, ὅσῳ περ γεραίτατός εἰμι, τοσούτῳ προθυμότερα μανθάνειν μετὰ τῶν νεανίσκων. ἀλλὰ μοι οὕτως πείσῃσιν· αὐρίον ἔωθεν ἀφίκου οἴκαδε καὶ μὴ ἄλλως ποιήσης, ἵνα βουλευσώμεθα περὶ αὐτῶν τούτων, τὸ δὲ νῦν εἶναι τὴν συνουσίαν διαλύσωμεν. ΣΩ. ἀλλὰ ποιήσω, ὦ Λυσίμαχε, ταῦτα, καὶ ἤξω παρὰ σέ αὐρίον, ἐὰν θεὸς ἐθέλῃ.

**S:** I shall do as you ask, Lysimachus, and come to you tomorrow, God willing.

## Notes

<sup>1</sup> Nicias and Laches were Athenian generals during the Peloponnesian War. Nicias was also a politician, best known for negotiating the ‘Peace of Nicias’, a temporary armistice between Athens and Sparta.

<sup>2</sup> Damon of Athens was a noted musicologist and teacher of Pericles. Republic 400b ff and Alcibiades I 118c.

<sup>3</sup> Delium was the site of an Athenian defeat by the Boeotians during the Peloponnesian War. Socrates’ bravery during this battle is referred to in a number of Plato’s dialogues.

<sup>4</sup> Iliad v.229-238.

<sup>5</sup> This was a legendary wild pig which wreaked havoc on the village of Crommyon (between Corinth and Megara) before it was slain by Theseus.

<sup>6</sup> Lamachus was an Athenian general during the Peloponnesian War. He, together with Nicias and Alcibiades, commanded the Sicilian Expedition.

<sup>7</sup> Someone from the Athenian deme of Aexone. They had a reputation for being abusive speakers.

<sup>8</sup> Odyssey xvii.347.